

"Massive attack coming ... wait, never mind, they want to negotiate. That's theatre diplomacy on loop. We don't need more theatre."

Iran's Parliament Speaker **Bagher Ghalibaf** accuses US of 'bullying' in talks

YOUR RIGHT TO KNOW

The Daily Star

SECOND EDITION

DHAKA SATURDAY AUGUST 8, 2026

REGD. NO. DA 781 | VOL. XXXVI NO. 193 | SRABAN 24, 1433 BS | www.thedailystar.net | SAFAR 24, 1448 HIJRI | 16 PAGES: TK 15.00



Teacher shortages strain government primary schools

More than half of the schools running without headteachers

Number of govt primary schools	Vacant head teacher posts	Vacant assistant teacher posts	Total teachers in the schools
65,567	36,235	13,500	3.87 lakh

MOHIUDDIN ALAMGIR *and* **ARAFAT RAHAMAN**

Government primary schools across Bangladesh are struggling to keep lessons on track as headteacher posts remain vacant in more than half of the institutions while thousands of assistant-teacher positions also remain unfilled, putting extra pressure on teachers and disrupting classes.

Teachers are being forced to take additional classes, cover multiple subjects and shoulder administrative duties, a strain affecting classroom instruction and the quality of education.

Education Minister ANM Ehsanul Hoque Milon recently confirmed that 36,235 headteacher posts remain vacant in the country's 65,567 government primary schools.

The government says a long-standing legal dispute over headteacher appointments has now been resolved and recruitment is set to begin.

It also says the assistant-teacher shortage is nearly resolved, with more than 14,000 newly recruited teachers expected to join after training.



- Schools are cancelling classes
- Many teachers are overworked
- Teaching quality is suffering

At West Nangla Government Primary School in Madarganj upazila of Jamalpur, five teaching posts are sanctioned, but the school has been operating with just one teacher since January 15.

Headteacher Abdul Momin now runs the entire school alone, teaching 70 students while also handling administrative work.

"The shortage of teachers has made

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The mangled Bengal Paribahan bus after a head-on collision with another bus in Sylhet's Osmaninagar upazila. *Inset,* Rina Begum breaks down at the hospital while claiming the body of her husband, Abu Sayed, a farm worker, who was killed by a bus on the Bogura-Naogaon highway.

PHOTO: STAR, COLLECTED

A search for work ends in tragedy

MOSTAFA SHABUJ, *Bogura*

It was still dark out. Right after Fajr prayers, around 200 farm workers for hire -- some with towels slung over their shoulders, others carrying small bags -- gathered at an informal labour market in Erulia Bazar of Bogura Sadar upazila.

They were waiting in the hope of finding a day's work. But before many could do so, tragedy struck. A speeding bus ploughed into the crowd, a witness said.

Describing the horror, Habibur Rahman, 30, from Enayetpur village in Gaibandha's

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16 killed in Sylhet, Bogura road crashes

2 buses collide head-on in Sylhet; another runs over labourers in Bogura

STAR REPORT

At least 16 people, including five labourers, were killed and 48 others injured in road crashes in Sylhet and Bogura yesterday.

In Sylhet's Osmaninagar upazila, two buses collided head-on.

A video, circulating on social media, shows that a Bengal Paribahan bus lost control and hit another bus of Unique Paribahan that fall into a roadside ditch on Dhaka-Sylhet highway at Kashikapan around 7:00am.

Nine passengers of the Dhaka-bound Unique Paribahan bus died. At least 24 others of the two vehicles were injured.

Several witnesses told reporters that the Bengal Paribahan bus veered onto the right side of the road while attempting to overtake a pickup, before colliding head-on with the Unique Paribahan bus at high speed.

Four of the nine deceased have been identified as Saiful Islam, 50, of Kishoreganj; Peheli Bhairabi, 17, of the same district; Faiza, 3, daughter of Jahangir of Sylhet city; and Saptam Roy Pritam, 22, of the city's Sobhanighat area.

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Construction of the Dhaka-Ashulia Elevated Expressway has severely damaged sections of the Dhaka-Tangail highway in Baipail, Ashulia, near the Dhaka Export Processing Zone. Large potholes, broken asphalt and waterlogged stretches are hampering traffic, causing daily congestion and increasing the risk of accidents. The photo was taken on Thursday.

PHOTO: PALASH KHAN

DELHI PRESS MEET

Indian govt says it doesn't endorse Hasina's remarks

DIPLOMATIC CORRESPONDENT

India yesterday said it does not endorse anything said by deposed Bangladeshi prime minister Sheikh Hasina and other Awami League leaders at a media event in New Delhi on August 5.

"So let me say that I have already stated government's position on the issue before the press conference happened. You would have seen those remarks. You were present here. I am reiterating it here," said Randhir Jaiswal, spokesperson for India's Ministry of External Affairs, at a media briefing in New Delhi.

He said the India government had no role to play in what was an event by a private media entity and the "government does not endorse anything said at the forum, especially with regard to the duly constituted government of Bangladesh".

The Foreign Correspondents' Club of South Asia hosted the event where Hasina, her son Sajeeb Wazed Joy, and other leaders spoke. It was broadcast live via social media.

Hasina, who fled to India on August

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PRESIDENTIAL ELECTION

A process shackled by provisions

MOHIUDDIN ALAMGIR

When Mohammed Shahabuddin resigned as president on July 24, the spotlight immediately shifted to who would succeed him at Bangabhaban.

Amid speculation, all the names that surfaced were linked to the ruling party, continuing a pattern that has persisted since independence.

Bangladesh has so far held 12 presidential elections -- three direct polls in which citizens voted and nine indirect ones in which MPs cast ballots. Of these indirect polls, eight were uncontested, with ruling party candidates elected unopposed.

The direct polls, held before parliamentary democracy was restored in 1991, were often criticised as rigged. Indirect elections under the parliamentary system, meanwhile, have become more ritual than contest.

Article 70, which bars MPs from voting against their party, along with open voting and parliamentary majorities, has reduced presidential elections to mere formalities in which opposition candidates rarely even enter the race.

The first presidential election, held on January 24, 1974, was indirect. Awami League candidate Mohammad Mohammadullah was elected unopposed.

The next presidential election -- the first direct one -- was held on June 3, 1978. Ziaur Rahman formed the Bangladesh Jatiyatabadi Front (Nationalist Front), a coalition of six parties, to contest as its candidate. His main rival was General MAG Osmani,

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DHAKA UNIVERSITY MEMORIES

Nocturnal adventures in a city that doesn't sleep

ASHIF AHMED RUDRO

MY DHAKA







PHOTO: STAR

Dhaka means different things to different people. Some people loathe it for nuisances while others love it for some unexplained reason. For me, Dhaka holds a special place in my heart for such very specific reason. This is the city that plays host to my campus.

Call me nostalgia merchant, DU brat, or whatever else comes to mind, but Dhaka University holds a very special place in my heart and my life. One of my favourite recollections are the memories of my adventures in the city. It started in the first year.

As you can imagine, first year students are reckless, adventurous, and inquisitive. For many of us, this was our first time in Dhaka. For others, this was the first taste of independence in a city that was wonderous and so much more. So, we set to explore.

Our explorations usually started late; after 10:00pm.

In the beginning it was the campus. There were numerous halls; each with its own characteristic and interests. Winter nights brought a different sense of adventure. The fog on the road and dew drops on the grass and roads brought a feeling of romanticism that probably sounds silly to others but DU campus is still one of the few places in the city where you can actually walk in fog and not smog.

Then we grew bolder. Our walks became longer and we explored the other campuses around us. Then came the adventures. We started looking for what can we explore. And being a student, how can we go there cheaper?

One day I ended up at Trimohini Bridge, a place near Khilgaon. Back then, it was rather remote. The commute had felt like a test of endurance and the overall look of the place was a bit spooky at that time. I arrived there after sundown with a friend and we ended up having to stay with another friend (who lived nearby fortunately) because by then, it was too late to come back safely.

Another day, we hitchhiked all the way across town to Jahangirnagar University in the middle of the night because we heard stories of how beautiful that campus is during winter nights.

Whenever we felt like going somewhere but could not decide on a destination, Nazira Bazaar was our go-to solution. It may not sound like much too many, but back then, it was an extraordinary place to us. Nazira Bazaar is hauntingly buzzing after midnight, and it suited us just fine. A little bit of chicken chaap, Beauty's lassi, and fire paan; those were the nights that stays with us forever.

After the meal, we used to walk randomly in old Dhaka, which, in hindsight, might not have been the safest thing to do, but fortunately we never got into trouble; perhaps because we always went out in groups. I still remember the horses, donkeys, and the strong earthy smell on the road like it was yesterday.

By the time we were walking back to the campus, we could feel the cold breeze of the oncoming morning. The first pale light of dawn cutting through the dark sky and the night lights slowly going out made everything surreal; these are the scenes you read about in a fantasy book. But not us, we lived those moments. Countless times.

Now in my late twenties, my body is unable to entertain the strain of an all-nighter, and I live away from the campus. I will not get on Dhaka streets unless I absolutely have to. But back then, we didn't care. And we were free. Battered by the existential crisis of a man nearing his thirties, I wonder.... can't I go back?

Chhatra Dal leader falls to death during police raid

OUR CORRESPONDENT, *Savar*



Monowarul Hossain Bakshi

A Chhatra Dal leader died after falling from the rooftop of a residential building during a police operation in Savar early yesterday.

The deceased was identified as Monowarul Hossain Bakshi, 29, vice-president of the Savar unit of Jatiyatabadi Chhatra Dal and son of Md Jafar Ali, a security guard at the Bangladesh Public Administration Training Centre.

Saiful Alam, officer-in-charge of Savar Model Police Station, said officers from Pirgachha Police Station in Rangpur, assisted by Savar police, raided Jafar Ali's flat at the BPATC Staff Quarters while searching for a missing teenage girl and her companion.

During the operation, Monowarul went to the rooftop.

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BNP leader shot from moving car in Pallabi

Woman passerby also injured

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

A local BNP leader and a female passerby were shot after assailants opened fire from a moving car in Dhaka's Pallabi yesterday.

Alamgir Hossain, 45, a member of Nawabganj upazila BNP and a fish trader, was admitted to Dhaka Medical College Hospital, said Md Mostak Sarkar, deputy commissioner of the Dhaka Metropolitan Police's Mirpur Division.

He sustained bullet wounds to his head and abdomen, said Inspector Md Faruk, in-charge of the DMCH police outpost.

The other victim, Josna, 50, who suffered a bullet wound to her leg, was admitted to Kurmitola General Hospital, police said. The shooting took place around 5:45pm in Lane 2 of Millat Camp in Mirpur-11.

DC Mostak said investigators identified the alleged shooters as Rubel, alias "Langra Rubel", and his associate Pappa. They are known drug peddlers and drives are underway to arrest them, he added.

Pallabi Police Station Officer-in-Charge Hasan Bashir said the attackers arrived in a car, fired three rounds at Alamgir and fled the scene. The family suspects the attack may have been linked to political rivalry.

Teacher shortages strain govt primary schools

FROM PAGE 1

many guardians reluctant to admit their children to this school," he said.

The headteacher serves as the school's academic and administrative leader, overseeing daily operations and supervising teachers, maintaining records, and communicating with local communities and government offices.

When the post remains vacant, an assistant teacher has to take on those responsibilities while continuing to teach, reducing the number of teachers available in classrooms, officials said.

At North Rasulpur Government Primary School in Cumilla Sadar upazila, the headteacher post has been vacant for nearly a decade.

Assistant teacher Mohammad Manjurul Alam has been performing the duties of headteacher while continuing to teach the school's 225 students, handling administrative, financial and official responsibilities as well.

"Handling both duties simultaneously naturally reduces the time and attention I can devote to teaching, affecting the quality of education," Manjurul said.

LEGAL COMPLICATIONS

Officials at the Directorate of Primary Education (DPE) said many schools have remained without headteachers for years because of legal complications over recruitment, seniority and promotion.

Under the existing rules, 20 percent of headteacher posts are filled through direct recruitment and 80 percent through promotion from among assistant teachers.

A 2017 writ petition challenged a provision of the 2013 Recruitment Rules relating to seniority, stalling the process of filling many of the posts.

A major obstacle was removed on July 2, when the Appellate Division of the Supreme Court overturned a High Court verdict that had struck down part of the rules governing seniority and promotion.

Officials at the primary and mass education ministry said a formal requisition would soon be sent to the Public Service Commission for direct recruitment and promotion under special arrangements.

ASSISTANT-TEACHER SHORTAGE

In October last year, then DPE director general Abu Noor Md Shamsuzzaman said around 13,500 assistant-teacher posts were vacant across the country.

At Sonarua Government Primary School in Kapasia upazila of Gazipur, only four teachers are serving against six sanctioned posts.

Acting headteacher Ashraful Islam said around three classes are cancelled every day because there are simply not enough teachers.

"A teacher has to take two to three additional classes every day," he said, adding that he sometimes has to teach Bangla, religion and English.

Parent Lipi Akter said, "My child has become inattentive and now needs private tuition. I will change the school."

State Minister Bobby Hajjaj said the assistant-teacher shortage is now much smaller, with only around 2,000 more teachers needed.

The 14,000 newly recruited teachers are currently undergoing police verification and they will receive two months of training.

"They are basically two to two and a half months behind schedule in entering classrooms," he said.

There are currently 3,87,000 teachers serving in government primary schools across the country.

DISPARITIES

DPE's Annual Sector Performance Report 2024, released in January this year, found that 12,935 government primary schools were operating with four or fewer teachers.

Of those, 133 schools had only one teacher and 633 had only two teachers.

"At the lower end, extremely understaffed schools persist... operating with minimal human resources. Such conditions severely impact classroom instructional quality and multi-grade management," the report said.

According to 2023 data cited in the report, the average number of teachers per government primary school across Bangladesh was 6.29.

Chattogram had the highest average number of teachers per school at 6.65, followed by Dhaka at 6.52 and Rajshahi at 6.46.

At the other end, Sylhet had an average of 5.59 teachers per school and Barishal 5.89.

"These discrepancies point to regional disparities that may affect the consistency and quality of education delivery," the report said.

At No. 24 Purba Aliabad Government Primary School in Faridpur Sadar upazila, only three teachers are working against five sanctioned posts.

Class III student Sihab Molla said the shortage directly affected lessons.

"One teacher often teaches two classes at the same time and sometimes leaves one class before finishing the lesson," he said.

LEARNING OUTCOMES AT RISK

Educationists say inadequate teaching, crowded classrooms, poor student-teacher interaction and inadequate infrastructure are already affecting the quality of primary education.

The staffing problem is particularly concerning because it comes against a backdrop of weak learning outcomes.

The National Student Assessment 2022 report of the DPE found that 61 percent of Class III students and 70 percent of Class V students lacked grade-appropriate proficiency in mathematics.

In Bangla, 51 percent of Class III students and 50 percent of Class V students lacked the required competency.

Rasheda K Choudhury, executive director of Campaign for Popular Education (CAMPE), said the teacher shortage had persisted for years and worsened in some areas since the Covid-19 pandemic.

"I do not understand why these problems are not being solved," she said.

She said weaker students suffer the most because understaffed schools have little scope to provide remedial support.

Recruitment delays caused by legal complications, difficulties in finding qualified teachers and reluctance among some teachers to serve in remote areas have all contributed to the problem, she said.

The shortage also places additional pressure on existing teachers, she said, adding, "We have not prioritised teachers for many years."

16 killed in Sylhet, Bogura road crashes

FROM PAGE 1

Peheli was a Baul singer. She was on the way to Dhaka after performing at an event in Sylhet, her acquaintances said.

Faruk Miah, 52, of Kuliarchar in Kishoreganj, a Unique Paribahan passenger injured in the crash, said he, along with his four friends, had come to Sylhet to visit the shrine of Hazrat Shahjalal (RA). Two of them flew back to Dhaka, and he and the other two boarded the bus.

"I was dozing off at the time of the accident. A loud sound and crash woke me up. People carried me to the hospital. My friend Saiful Islam was killed."

Brig Gen Umar Rashed Munir, director of Osmani Medical College Hospital, said 16 people were admitted to the hospital. Of them, a child died first and another patient afterwards, he said, adding that the 14 others were undergoing treatment.

BOGURA CRASH

Seven people were killed when a speeding bus ran over labourers waiting for work by the Bogura-Naogaon regional highway near Erulia Bazar in Bogura Sadar upazila around 5:30am yesterday.

Five of them were day labourers, while the rest had come to hire them.

Monjur-A-Morshed, deputy director of Shaheed Ziaur Rahman Medical College Hospital, said 24 injured were admitted to the facility and 19 of them were undergoing treatment.

The deceased have been identified as Tazimul, 47, of Dinajpur; Bellal Hossain, of Bogura Sadar upazila; Nur Mohammad, 76, of the same district; Abu Sayeed, 45, of Gaibandha; Nur Alam, 45, of the same district; Anarul, 55, of Joypurhat; and Amirul, 40, of the same district.

Shahidul Islam, senior station officer of the Bogura fire service office, told The Daily Star that the brakes of Naogaon-bound Shah Fateh Ali Paribahan bus coming from Dhaka failed when the vehicle gave the way to a motorcycle. The bus first struck an electricity pole, then crashed into labourers and people who had come to hire them, he said.

Three died on the spot.

Doctors declared three dead after being taken to the hospital, while another died later.

Shahidul said locals, transport workers, and firefighters rescued the victims and sent them to the hospital.

Labourer Md Borhan, who was present at the scene, told this newspaper, "Around 200 workers were waiting at the spot this morning. Suddenly, a speeding bus veered onto our side of the road to avoid a collision with an oncoming motorcycle. I ran and somehow managed to survive, but one person from my village was killed, and six others have been hospitalised."

Bogura Sadar Upazila Nirbahi Officer Abdul Wazed said locals blocked the road at the scene, demanding speed breakers to prevent further crashes. The executive engineer of the Roads and Highways Department visited the spot and assured the protesters that speed breakers would be installed there soon, he added.

Bogura Deputy Commissioner Toufiqur Rahman said the family of each deceased person would receive Tk 25,000, while each injured would be provided Tk 15,000. He added that the government would bear all treatment costs for the injured.

Meanwhile, a three-member committee, led by Bogura Additional District Magistrate Masud Hossain, has been formed to identify those responsible for the crash and asked to submit its report within three working days.

According to the Bogura office of Bangladesh Road Transport Authority (BRTA), the bus had been operating without a route permit for the past one and a half years.

Asked about the matter, DC Toufiqur told The Daily Star said that once the investigation is completed, action will be taken.

[Our correspondents in Sylhet and Bogura contributed to this report.]

A process shackled by provisions

FROM PAGE 1

commander-in-chief of the Bangladesh Forces during the Liberation War, who ran as the candidate of Gonotantrik Oikya Jote, a coalition of five parties including the Awami League.

Apart from Zia and Osmani, eight other candidates contested. According to Election Commission data and the book Bangladesher Nirbachon Bebostha o Folalfol edited by Nesar Amin, Zia won 77 percent of the vote, while Osmani received 22 percent.

Muhammad Yeahia Akhter, in his book "Electoral Corruption in Bangladesh", wrote that there were allegations that the election was "rigged," and the opposition candidate publicly asserted it was "grossly unfree and unfair." He noted that political parties operated openly for the first time since the August 1975 coup, and Zia was successful in "legitimising" his position through a contested election.

Following Zia's assassination on May 30, 1981, by a faction of army officers, vice president Abdus Sattar became acting president. Sattar contested the presidential election on November 15, 1981 as the BNP's nominee and won. A total of 31 candidates contested, but his nearest rival was Awami League's Dr Kamal Hossain. Sattar secured 66 percent of the vote, while Kamal received 26 percent.

Yeahia Akhter wrote that after the polls, the AL promptly accused the ruling party of "extensive poll-rigging" and announced plans for demonstrations and nationwide protests. The BNP rejected the allegations, claiming their victory was a clear verdict in favour of continuing the process of democratisation and economic development initiated by Zia.

Sattar was later overthrown in a bloodless coup in March 1982 by Army Chief Hussain Muhammad Ershad, who assumed the presidency in 1983.

The third and last direct presidential election was held on October 15, 1986, boycotted by all major opposition parties, including BNP and AL. Ershad, running as the candidate of Jatiya Party formed earlier that year, faced 12 contenders. His nearest rival was Muhammadullah, commonly known as Hafezzi Hujur. Ershad won 84 percent of the vote, while Muhammadullah received 6 percent.

After Ershad's fall in the wake of a mass uprising, Bangladesh returned to a parliamentary system in 1991. Since then, nine presidential elections have been held indirectly.

Lawmakers have voted only once in a contested presidential election. In October 1991, BNP nominee Abdur Rahman Biswas won with 172 votes against Awami League candidate and former chief justice Badrul Haider Chowdhury, who received 92.

All subsequent elections were uncontested, with ruling party candidates elected unopposed.

Awami League's Shahabuddin Ahmed in 1996, BNP's AQM Badruddoza Chowdhury in 2001, BNP's Iajuddin Ahmed in 2002, Awami League's Zillur Rahman in 2009, Awami League's Abdul Hamid in 2013 and 2018, and Awami League's Mohammed Shahabuddin in 2023, won the polls.

WHY THE RESULT IS CERTAIN

Article 48 (1) of the 1972 Constitution stated that the president would be elected by MPs in accordance with the Second Schedule of the Constitution that introduced a secret ballot system of voting. Paragraph (12a) even allowed for cancellation of a ballot if there was any sign of identification of the voter.

This gave MPs a certain liberty to vote for any candidate they preferred, although Article 70 barred lawmakers from voting against their party.

The Second Schedule was omitted through the Fourth Amendment of January 25, 1975, which shifted the country to a presidential system and introduced direct elections for the presidency.

After the 12th Amendment was passed in September 1991, parliamentary democracy was restored. Presidential elections returned to an indirect format, but open voting was introduced.

Since then, Article 70 has shaped the outcome of presidential elections.

"Since MPs are the ones who vote, Article 70 is one of the reasons there are no opposition winners and so many unopposed polls. As ruling parties must hold the majority, for opposition joining the presidential polls has little meaning," said former Chittagong University professor and parliamentary affairs expert Nizam Ahmed.

Election expert Abdul Alim said open voting has reduced the process to a formality.

"If an MP votes against his party's candidate, everyone will know. So even if he wants to vote for [anyone other than his party candidate] he is compelled to vote for his party nominee.

"The opposition knows it has no chance of winning. These elections are merely ornamental. Since there is no chance of victory, why would anyone become a candidate unnecessarily?" he added.

A search for work ends in tragedy

FROM PAGE 1

Gobindaganj upazila said there was currently no farm work available in his village.

"Meanwhile, the Aman paddy planting season is in full swing in Bogura's Sadar, Kahaloo, and Dupchanchia upazilas. So, a dozen workers from our village arrived in the district 10 to 12 days ago."

In Gaibandha, with a full day of hard labour Habibur earned Tk 500 to Tk 700. In Bogura, however, contract work for planting paddy paid Tk 800 to Tk 1,200 a day.

"That extra income was our only hope of keeping our families afloat."

But those hopes were shattered in an instant. Habibur's uncle, Abu Sayed, 45, was among the seven people killed in the crash.

"Sayed chacha [uncle] was the sole earner for his five-member family. His elderly parents were waiting at home for him to return. He was supposed to go back in just a few days, but the crash took him before he could," Habibur lamented.

After receiving the news, Abu Sayed's wife, Rina Begum, rushed to Bogura Shaheed Ziaur Rahman Medical College Hospital to claim her husband's body.

As the sheet covering his body was pulled back, her cries echoed through the hospital. Overcome with grief, she kept fainting as relatives tried to console her.

"Where did you go, leaving me all alone?" she cried.

Md Borhan, 25, another worker from Enayetpur, recalled the terrifying moment. A farmer from Kahaloo had just arrived at the market to hire labourers when a speeding bus swerved sharply to avoid a motorcycle.

The bus lost control, hit a roadside electric pole, spun around and ploughed into the crowd of waiting workers.

"Some managed to run to safety, but seven people were crushed under the bus. Most of those killed were the sole breadwinners of their families."

Borhan appealed for government support for the victims' families, saying that without assistance, many could be pushed into severe financial hardship.

According to police and hospital sources, five agricultural labourers and two farmers who had come to hire workers were killed in the crash on the Bogura-Naogaon regional highway. Nineteen others are receiving treatment in hospital, including two in critical condition in the intensive care unit.

Around 250 to 300 day labourers from neighbouring districts gather at the informal labour market in Erulia every day before sunrise in search of work.

‘Branding govt a failure so soon reflects intolerance’

Says Mirza Fakhrul

STAFF CORRESPONDENT



LGRD Minister and BNP Secretary General Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir yesterday said branding the government a “failure” before it has completed “even five months” in office reflects extreme political and social intolerance.

“We become restless over very small things. It has not even been five months, and we are already saying that this government has failed. This is just intolerance... extreme intolerance,” he said.

Fakhrul made the remarks while addressing a seminar titled “The Role of the Media in Sustainable Democracy”, organised by the Television Editors Council (TEC) at a Dhaka hotel.



A woman crawls under a temporary road divider amid moving traffic to cross the road. In the absence of a footbridge, locals are forced to climb over or crawl beneath such dividers to reach the other side. The photo was taken near the Mohammadpur Dhaka Udyan residential area yesterday.

PHOTO: RASHED SHUMON

24% children under five suffer from stunting

Shows BBS survey; experts blame poverty, poor nutrition, early pregnancy and unhealthy feeding practices

ABDULLAH HEL BUBUN

Nearly one in four Bangladeshi children under the age of five are too short for their age because of chronic malnutrition and poor health during early childhood, according to a national survey.

The Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics’ (BBS) Multiple Indicator Cluster Survey (MICS) 2025, published last month with technical support from Unicef, found that 24 percent of children under five are moderately or severely stunted.

Stunting -- when a child is significantly shorter than the World Health Organization’s growth standard for their age -- is one of the clearest indicators of chronic malnutrition. It reflects nutritional deprivation during the first 1,000 days of life, a critical period for physical and brain development.

Stunting -- when a child is significantly shorter than the WHO’s growth standard for their age -- is one of the clearest indicators of chronic malnutrition. It reflects nutritional deprivation during the first 1,000 days of life.

AT A GLANCE

- Study covers over 23,000 children
- Stunting has fallen from 59.6% in 1997
- 34.3% children in poorest households are stunted
- Rural children fare worse than urban ones
- Boys are slightly more affected than girls
- Bangladesh remains in WHO’s “high” category, ranked 49th among 163 countries

The survey, based on measurements of more than 23,000 children nationwide, also reveals sharp inequalities.

Children from the poorest households are more than twice as likely to be stunted as those from the richest -- 34.3 percent compared with 15.2 percent. Rural children fare worse than urban children, while boys are affected slightly more than girls.

Bangladesh has made remarkable progress over the past three decades, cutting child stunting from 59.6 percent in 1997 to 24 percent in 2025.

Even so, the country remains in the WHO’s “high prevalence” category. WHO classifies national stunting rates between 20 and 30 percent as high, while rates above 30 percent are considered very high.

Bangladesh first moved out of the “very high” category in 2019, when MICS recorded a stunting rate of 28 percent. The latest findings show further improvement, but not enough to leave the high-prevalence group.

Tajuddin Sikder, professor of public health and informatics at Jahangirnagar University, said child stunting in Bangladesh results from a combination of chronic malnutrition, unhealthy feeding practices, environmental pollution and a lack of opportunities for physical activity, particularly in crowded urban areas where open play spaces are disappearing.

Compared with the rest of the world, Bangladesh continues to lag behind many countries with similar or even lower income levels.

An analysis by The Daily Star using the latest Unicef data from 163 countries found Bangladesh ranks 49th highest for child stunting. In other words, nearly two-thirds of countries report lower rates.

Although Bangladesh performs better than Afghanistan (44.6 percent), Pakistan (37.6 percent) and India (35.5 percent), its stunting rate remains more than double that of Sri Lanka (10.5 percent). It also trails Bhutan (17.9 percent) and the Maldives (15.3 percent).

The consequences extend far beyond height.

Stunted children are more vulnerable to infections such as acute respiratory illnesses and diarrhoeal diseases, increasing their risk of death in early childhood.

The condition also affects brain development, reducing cognitive ability, delaying learning and limiting educational attainment.

According to a World Bank study, stunted children are more likely to enrol in school later, repeat grades and complete fewer years of education than their peers.

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India flouts norms over Hasina press conference

Says Jamaat

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

Bangladesh Jamaat-e-Islami yesterday termed India’s decision to allow fugitive former prime minister Sheikh Hasina to address a press conference in New Delhi a “gross violation” of diplomatic norms.

In a statement, Jamaat Secretary General Mia Golam Porwar alleged that India was ignoring Bangladesh’s diplomatic appeals by continuing to shelter Hasina and allowing her to engage in political activities from its capital.

Hasina, who was sentenced to death in a crimes against humanity case, addressed the press conference in New Delhi on Wednesday night, coinciding with the second anniversary of the July uprising, drawing strong resentment from the Bangladesh government.

Porwar said Bangladesh sought to maintain relations with all countries, including neighbouring India, on the basis of mutual respect and equality, but accused New Delhi of disregarding Dhaka’s repeated requests regarding Hasina.

Calling the move a violation of international norms and diplomatic etiquette, he urged the government to take more effective steps, including seeking an Interpol red notice and UN assistance, to bring Hasina back.

Ramisa rape and murder case yet to reach HC bench

ASHUTOSH SARKAR

Although a dedicated High Court bench was constituted 52 days ago exclusively to hear and dispose of death references and appeals in cases involving crimes against women and children, it has yet to begin hearing the widely discussed Ramisa Akter rape and murder case.

On June 7, the Women and Children Repression Prevention Tribunal in Dhaka sentenced Sohel, the prime accused, to death. It also sentenced Swapna to death for assisting him in the crime.

Ramisa, a second-grader at Popular Model High School in Dhaka’s Pallabi area, was found beheaded in the house of her neighbour Sohel Rana on May 19.

The following day, Ramisa’s father, Abdul Hannan Mollah, filed a case with Pallabi Police Station against Sohel, his wife Swapna Khatun and an unidentified person.

Sohel called eight-year-old Ramisa into his room and raped her. Investigators said he later slit her throat and attempted to dismember her body to conceal the crime.

On June 7, the Women and Children Repression

SEE PAGE 4 COL 1

Fish and poultry prices rise, veggies get cheaper

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

Prices of fish, poultry chicken and eggs have risen in the capital’s kitchen markets over the past week, while prices of vegetables declined.

Visiting markets in Shewrapara, Kazipara, Ibrahimpur, Farmgate, Karwan Bazar and Mirpur-11 over the past two days, this correspondent found that prices of most vegetables fell by Tk 10-20 per kg compared to last week.

Green chilli recorded the sharpest decline, dropping to Tk 200-280 per kg from Tk 400-500 following the start of imports from India.

Papaya was selling at Tk 25-30 per kg, bottle gourds at Tk 50-80 each, while onion prices fell by Tk 5 per kg. Most other vegetables were retailing between Tk 40 and Tk 100 per kg.



STAR FILE PHOTO

Vegetable trader Nur Islam said improved supply had pushed prices down after two weeks of higher rates.

Meanwhile, egg prices increased by Tk 10 per dozen, while broiler and Sonali chicken rose by Tk 10-20 per kg. Prices of most farmed fish also rose by Tk 20-30 per kg.

Broiler chicken was selling at Tk 190-200 per kg, while farmed rohu retailed at Tk 300-380, katla at Tk 300-360, tilapia at Tk 180-250, koi at Tk 200-250 and pangas at Tk 160-200 per kg.

“Even though vegetable prices dropped, there is no relief for low-income people like us as fish, poultry and egg prices rose,” said Qayyum Hossain, 65, a customer at Karwan Bazar.

SEE PAGE 4 COL 3

3 of a family suffer burns in gas explosion

OUR CORRESPONDENT, *N’ganj*

Three members of a family suffered severe burn injuries in a suspected gas explosion at their house in Kuripara of Narayanganj’s Bandar upazila yesterday morning.

The injured are Maidul Islam, 24, his wife Beauty Akter, 22, and their eight-year-old son Maruf, fire service officials said.

They were admitted to the National Institute of Burn and Plastic Surgery, where all three were reported to be in critical condition.

Quoting neighbours who brought them to the hospital, Dr Shawon Bin Rahman, resident surgeon at the institute’s emergency department, said the explosion occurred around 6:30am when Maidul struck a match to light a cigarette inside the house.

Maidul sustained burns to 85 percent of his body, while Beauty and Maruf suffered burns to 90 percent and 80 percent of their bodies respectively, he said.

Abdullah Al Arefin, deputy assistant director of Narayanganj Fire Service and Civil Defence, said a preliminary inquiry suggested gas had accumulated inside the room due to a leak, triggering the explosion.



Illegal roadside stalls occupy much of the space in front of the emergency department at Dhaka Medical College Hospital. The encroachment often makes it difficult for patients and ambulances to access the hospital. The photo was taken yesterday.

PHOTO: MEHEDI HASAN

Content creator held over rape of 15-yr-old girl

OUR CORRESPONDENT, *Netrokona*

A content creator was arrested early yesterday in connection with a case over the alleged rape of a 15-year-old girl in Netrokona Sadar.

A Rab team arrested Ripon Mia from Mohisharon Achintapur area in Gouripur around 12:05am and later handed him over to Netrokona police, said Maj Mir Ishtiyaque Amin, company commander of Rab-14 Mymensingh Battalion.

The victim’s father filed the case on August 5 under the Women and Children Repression Prevention Act, 2000.

According to the case statement, Ripon, a neighbour of the victim, allegedly lured her with promises of making her viral on social media before calling her to the bank of the Mogra river on July 30 and raping her.

Netrokona Sadar Model Police Station Officer-in-Charge Abul Khayer said local influential people had initially attempted to settle the matter through a village arbitration, which reportedly fined the accused Tk 5 lakh and asked him to leave the area.

After a video of the arbitration circulated on social media, police contacted the victim’s family and encouraged them to file a case, the OC said.

Police said Ripon had remained absconding until his arrest yesterday.



Farmers sit near a seedbed in Pirojpur's Nazirpur upazila. Many of them are being forced to sell saplings at low prices and unable to cover their production costs. The photo was taken recently. PHOTO: STAR

NAZIRPUR UPAZILA IN PIROJPUR

Rain causes losses for sapling growers

HABIBUR RAHMAN, *Pirojpur*

Farmers producing vegetable saplings on floating seedbeds in Pirojpur's Nazirpur upazila have been counting losses due to sharp drop in market demand amid prolonged rainfall.

Many are being forced to sell saplings at low prices and are unable to cover their production costs.

Mohammad Yasain, a farmer from Mugarjhor village, said producing each pair of bottle gourd saplings costs at least Tk 4, but they are being forced to sell for only Tk 2, much below the usual price of Tk 7-8.

Farmers expressed concern that the losses will mount unless the weather improves soon.

Hundreds of farmers in Daulbari Dobra, Kolardoania and Malikhali unions of Nazirpur upazila, as well as Boldia union of neighbouring Nesarabad upazila, grow a wide range of seasonal vegetable saplings on floating seedbeds, including bottle gourd, bitter gourd, pumpkin, bean, papaya, chilli, eggplant and tomato.

According to the Department of Agricultural Extension, floating seedbeds have been prepared on around 190 hectares of marshland in Nazirpur this year.

Early in the season, however, bottle gourd saplings account for most of their production. A single floating seedbed can produce up to 1,200 bottle gourd saplings.

Seeds were planted around two months ago. The saplings became ready for sale within a month, but persistent rains disrupted demand during the peak marketing period, said farmers.

Mohammad Mohsin, another local farmer, said while they have been facing marketing difficulties during monsoon every year, this time the situation worsened.

Another farmer, Kawser Hossain, alleged that wholesale buyers are offering lower prices taking advantage of weak retail demand.

"As a result, we are unable to make any profit this time," he said.

Farmers also said they receive no financial assistance for producing vegetable saplings, and urged for support to survive the ongoing difficult circumstances.

Contacted, Esratunnesa Easha, upazila agriculture officer in Nazirpur, confirmed the matter and said they expect the situation to improve soon.

She added that there is currently no government financial assistance programme for vegetable sapling producers.

"If such assistance becomes available, we will provide support to them," she said.

24% children under five suffer

FROM PAGE 3

The MICS findings also showed that six in 10 children aged 7-14 could correctly read at least 90 percent of the words in a simple age-appropriate story, while only 40 percent demonstrated foundational numeracy skills.

The impact lasts well into adulthood. Studies show people who experienced childhood stunting earn about 20 percent less on average, are 30 percent more likely to live in poverty and are far less likely to secure skilled employment.

Researchers say the roots of stunting begin even before birth.

Nearly half of Bangladeshi women marry before the age of 18, while one in four becomes pregnant during adolescence, increasing nutritional risks for both mothers and babies.

The survey also found that one-third of pregnant women delay antenatal care until after the first trimester, while half do not receive the recommended minimum of four check-ups.

Poor diets remain another major challenge after birth.

Nearly two in three children aged six to 23 months do not consume enough food groups to meet their nutritional needs. More than half are fed processed foods, one in five consume sugary drinks, and one-third receive no fruits or vegetables.

To tackle the problem, Tajuddin called for greater investment in research on the causes of stunting, nationwide awareness campaigns on healthy feeding practices, and reforms to restore playgrounds in schools.

Healthy growth depends not only on nutrition but also on opportunities for physical activity, he said.

Ramisa rape and murder case

FROM PAGE 3

Prevention Tribunal in Dhaka sentenced Sohel, the prime accused, to death. It also sentenced Swapna to death for assisting him in the crime.

The judgement came 19 days after the incident that had sparked public outrage and prompted the government to pledge swift justice.

Chief Justice Zubayer Rahman Chowdhury on June 10 formed the High Court bench comprising Justice Bhishmadev Chakrabortty and Justice KM Rasheduzzaman Raja to deal with death sentences given under the Women and Children Repression Prevention Act.

The bench was tasked with hearing, on a priority basis, death references involving convictions under the law. It will also hear all criminal appeals and jail appeals arising from the same judgements, along with related applications and revision petitions.

However, it remains uncertain when the bench will begin hearing the death reference and appeals in Ramisa's case, as the judges are now hearing and disposing of previously registered cases of a similar nature, Deputy Attorney General Syed Ejaz Kabir told The Daily Star recently.

An official at the Supreme Court registrar general's office told The Daily Star on July 31 that the authorities had already prepared the paper-book in the Ramisa rape and murder case, clearing the way for the HC to hear the death reference and the appeals filed by the convicted couple.

A paper-book contains lower court judgements, orders, witness statements, evidence and other relevant documents required for the HC to adjudicate death references and related appeals.

The documents and paper-book in the case will be placed before the HC bench after the mandatory 60-day period for filing appeals expires.

The period expired yesterday, as the trial court delivered the verdict on June 7, according to the official.

The HC on June 14 admitted the appeals filed by Sohel and Swapna challenging the trial court verdict. The appeals had earlier been submitted through the jail authorities, according to sources.

Fish and

FROM PAGE 3

Redwan Hossain, who bought a rohu at Tk 350 per kg from Kazipara market, said farmed fish were widely available, but the supply of river and freshwater fish remained low, pushing prices sharply higher.

"You can't find freshwater fish for less than Tk 1,000 per kg. They are asking Tk 1,000 for a kg of shrimp too," he said.

Abdul Kadir, a fish trader at Karwan Bazar, said prices had risen due to a slump in the supply of both farmed and river fish amid rising water levels.

PRAYER TIMING
AUGUST 8

	Fazr	Zohr	Asr	Maghrib	Esha
AZAN	4-20	12-45	5-00	6-47	8-15
JAMAAT	4-55	1-15	5-15	6-50	8-45

SOURCE: ISLAMIC FOUNDATION

Happy 29th Birthday, Ibu.
Every day, you make me prouder. Thank you for every smile and every moment. Here's to many more birthdays together.
— Your Wife
Bushra

অ্যাভিয়েশন অ্যান্ড অ্যারোস্পেস বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়, বাংলাদেশ

(অ্যাভিয়েশন অ্যান্ড অ্যারোস্পেস সংক্রান্ত বিষয়ে বাংলাদেশের একমাত্র বিশেষায়িত সরকারি বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়)
ঢাকা ক্যাম্পাস : পুরাতন বিমান বন্দর, তেজগাঁও, ঢাকা-১২১৫।
ওয়েবঃ www.aaub.edu.bd, ই-মেইলঃ estb@aaub.edu.bd

এএইউবি/রেজিস্ট্রার-১৫৬/২০২৬/খন্ড-০২/২৪

তারিখঃ ২২ শ্রাবণ ১৪৩৩ / ০৬ আগষ্ট ২০২৬

সংশোধিত নিয়োগ বিজ্ঞপ্তি

গণপ্রজাতন্ত্রী বাংলাদেশ সরকারের ২০১৯ সনের ০৫ নং আইন দ্বারা প্রতিষ্ঠিত অ্যাভিয়েশন অ্যান্ড অ্যারোস্পেস বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়, বাংলাদেশ (এএইউবি) এর জন্য নিম্নবর্ণিত পদসমূহে নিয়োগের লক্ষ্যে প্রকৃত বাংলাদেশী নাগরিকগণের নিকট হতে আবেদনপত্র আহ্বান করা যাচ্ছে:

কর্মকর্তা ও কর্মচারীঃ

ক্র: নং	পদের নাম, পদের সংখ্যা, পদের ধরণ, গ্রেড, বেতন স্কেল ও বয়সসীমা	শিক্ষাগত যোগ্যতা ও অভিজ্ঞতা
১।	পরিচালক (পরিকল্পনা ও উন্নয়ন) ০১ (এক) টি, স্থায়ী পদ (গ্রেড-৩) ৫৬,৫০০-৭৪,৪০০/- ৫০ বৎসর	ক। কোনো স্বীকৃত বিশ্ববিদ্যালয় হইতে যেকোন বিষয়ে স্নাতকোত্তর ডিগ্রি থাকিতে হইবে। ইঞ্জিনিয়ারিং ডিগ্রীর ক্ষেত্রে বিএসসি ইঞ্জিনিয়ারিং গ্রহণযোগ্য। শিক্ষার কোনো স্তরেই ৩য় শ্রেণি/বিভাগ/সমমান গ্রেড গ্রহণযোগ্য হইবে না। খ। কোনো পাবলিক বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়/সরকারি/আধা-সরকারি/স্বায়ত্বশাসিত প্রতিষ্ঠানে অতিরিক্ত পরিচালক (পরিকল্পনা ও উন্নয়ন)/সমমান হিসেবে ০৫ বছরের অভিজ্ঞতাসহ ৯ম এবং তদূর্ধ্ব গ্রেডে মোট ১৪ বছরের চাকুরির অভিজ্ঞতা। গ। সংশ্লিষ্ট বিষয়ে যোগ্য ও অভিজ্ঞ প্রার্থীদের ক্ষেত্রে বয়সসীমা শিথিলযোগ্য।
২।	উপ-পরীক্ষা নিয়ন্ত্রক ০১ (এক) টি, স্থায়ী পদ (গ্রেড-৫) ৪৩,০০০-৬৯,৮৫০/- ৪০ বৎসর	ক। কোনো স্বীকৃত বিশ্ববিদ্যালয় হইতে স্নাতকোত্তর ডিগ্রি থাকিতে হইবে। উচ্চতর ডিগ্রি/প্রশিক্ষণ/কম্পিউটার ব্যবহারে দক্ষতাসম্পন্ন প্রার্থী অগ্রাধিকারযোগ্য। শিক্ষার কোনো স্তরেই ৩য় শ্রেণি/বিভাগ/সমমান গ্রেড গ্রহণযোগ্য হইবে না। খ। কোনো পাবলিক বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়ে সহকারী পরীক্ষা নিয়ন্ত্রক/সমমান পদে ন্যূনতম ৫ বছরের অভিজ্ঞতাসহ পাবলিক বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়/সরকারি/আধা-সরকারি/ডিগ্রি পর্যায়ের সরকারি শিক্ষা প্রতিষ্ঠানে ৯ম বা তদূর্ধ্ব গ্রেডে মোট ১০ বছরের চাকুরির অভিজ্ঞতা। গ। সংশ্লিষ্ট বিষয়ে যোগ্য ও অভিজ্ঞ প্রার্থীদের ক্ষেত্রে বয়সসীমা শিথিলযোগ্য।
৩।	উপ-পরিচালক (পাবলিক রিলেশন অ্যান্ড ইনফরফেশন) ০১ (এক) টি, স্থায়ী পদ (গ্রেড-৫) ৪৩,০০০-৬৯,৮৫০/- ৪০ বৎসর	ক। কোনো স্বীকৃত বিশ্ববিদ্যালয় হইতে সংশ্লিষ্ট বিষয়ে স্নাতকোত্তর ডিগ্রি থাকিতে হইবে। উচ্চতর ডিগ্রি/প্রশিক্ষণ/কম্পিউটার ব্যবহারে দক্ষতাসম্পন্ন প্রার্থী অগ্রাধিকারযোগ্য। শিক্ষার কোনো স্তরেই ৩য় শ্রেণি/বিভাগ/সমমান গ্রেড গ্রহণযোগ্য হইবে না। খ। কোনো পাবলিক বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়/সরকারি/আধা-সরকারি/স্বায়ত্বশাসিত প্রতিষ্ঠানে সংশ্লিষ্ট ক্ষেত্রে সহকারী পরিচালক/সমমান পদে ৫ বছরের অভিজ্ঞতাসহ ৯ম বা তদূর্ধ্ব গ্রেডে মোট ১০ বছরের চাকুরির অভিজ্ঞতা। গ। সংশ্লিষ্ট বিষয়ে যোগ্য ও অভিজ্ঞ প্রার্থীদের ক্ষেত্রে বয়সসীমা শিথিলযোগ্য।
৪।	উপ-পরিচালক (অর্থ ও হিসাব) ০১ (এক) টি, স্থায়ী পদ (গ্রেড-৫) ৪৩,০০০-৬৯,৮৫০/- ৪০ বৎসর	ক। কোনো স্বীকৃত বিশ্ববিদ্যালয় হইতে হিসাববিজ্ঞান/ফাইন্যান্স/ম্যানেজমেন্ট/মার্কেটিং/অর্থনীতি/ব্যবসায় শিক্ষা বিষয়ে স্নাতকোত্তর ডিগ্রি থাকিতে হইবে। উচ্চতর ডিগ্রি/প্রশিক্ষণ/কম্পিউটার ব্যবহারে দক্ষতাসম্পন্ন প্রার্থী অগ্রাধিকারযোগ্য। শিক্ষার কোনো স্তরেই ৩য় শ্রেণি/বিভাগ/সমমান গ্রেড গ্রহণযোগ্য হইবে না। খ। কোনো পাবলিক বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়/সরকারি/আধা-সরকারি/স্বায়ত্বশাসিত প্রতিষ্ঠানে সংশ্লিষ্ট ক্ষেত্রে সহকারী পরিচালক (অর্থ ও হিসাব/বাজেট/অডিট) সমমানের পদে কমপক্ষে ৫ বছরের অভিজ্ঞতাসহ ৯ম বা তদূর্ধ্ব গ্রেডে মোট ১০ বছরের চাকুরির অভিজ্ঞতা। গ। সংশ্লিষ্ট বিষয়ে যোগ্য ও অভিজ্ঞ প্রার্থীদের ক্ষেত্রে বয়সসীমা শিথিলযোগ্য।
৫।	সহকারী পরিচালক ০১ (এক) টি, স্থায়ী পদ (গ্রেড-৭) ২৯,০০০-৬৩,৪১০/- ৩৫ বৎসর	ক। কোনো স্বীকৃত বিশ্ববিদ্যালয় হইতে স্নাতকোত্তর ডিগ্রি থাকিতে হইবে। উচ্চতর ডিগ্রি/প্রশিক্ষণ/কম্পিউটার ব্যবহারে দক্ষতাসম্পন্ন প্রার্থী অগ্রাধিকারযোগ্য। শিক্ষার কোনো স্তরেই ৩য় শ্রেণি/বিভাগ/সমমান গ্রেড গ্রহণযোগ্য হইবে না। খ। কোনো পাবলিক বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়/সরকারি/আধা-সরকারি/স্বায়ত্বশাসিত প্রতিষ্ঠানে শিক্ষা অথবা প্রশাসন সংক্রান্ত কাজে ৯ম বা তদূর্ধ্ব গ্রেডে ৩ বছরের অভিজ্ঞতাসহ মোট ৫ বৎসরের চাকুরির অভিজ্ঞতা। গ। সংশ্লিষ্ট বিষয়ে যোগ্য ও অভিজ্ঞ প্রার্থীদের ক্ষেত্রে বয়সসীমা শিথিলযোগ্য।
৬।	সেকশন অফিসার ০২ (দুই) টি, স্থায়ী পদ (গ্রেড-৯) ২২,০০০-৫৩,০৬০/- ৩২ বৎসর	ক। কোনো স্বীকৃত বিশ্ববিদ্যালয় হইতে যে কোন বিষয়ে স্নাতক ডিগ্রি থাকিতে হইবে। শিক্ষার কোনো স্তরেই ৩য় শ্রেণি/বিভাগ/সমমান গ্রেড গ্রহণযোগ্য হইবে না। খ। কোনো পাবলিক বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়/সরকারি/আধা-সরকারি/স্বায়ত্বশাসিত প্রতিষ্ঠানে সংশ্লিষ্ট কাজে অভিজ্ঞতাসম্পন্ন প্রার্থী অগ্রাধিকারযোগ্য। গ। সংশ্লিষ্ট বিষয়ে যোগ্য ও অভিজ্ঞ প্রার্থীদের ক্ষেত্রে বয়সসীমা শিথিলযোগ্য।
৭।	ল্যাব টেকনিশিয়ান ০২ (দুই) টি, স্থায়ী পদ (গ্রেড-১১) ১২,৫০০-৩০,২৩০/- ৩২ বৎসর	ক। প্রার্থীকে ইলেকট্রিক্যাল/মেকানিক্যাল/কম্পিউটার ইঞ্জিনিয়ারিং/পদার্থবিদ্যা/রসায়নবিদ্যা/সংশ্লিষ্ট বিষয়ে ডিপ্লোমা। স্নাতকসহ ডিপ্লোমাধারী প্রার্থীদের অগ্রাধিকার দেওয়া হইবে; খ। কোনো পাবলিক বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়/সরকারি/আধা-সরকারি/স্বায়ত্বশাসিত প্রতিষ্ঠানে সংশ্লিষ্ট কাজে অভিজ্ঞতাসম্পন্ন প্রার্থী অগ্রাধিকারযোগ্য। গ। সংশ্লিষ্ট বিষয়ে যোগ্য ও অভিজ্ঞ প্রার্থীদের ক্ষেত্রে বয়সসীমা শিথিলযোগ্য।
৮।	স্টোর কিপার ০১ (এক) টি, স্থায়ী পদ (গ্রেড-১৩) ১১,০০০-২৬,৫৯০/- ৩২ বৎসর	ক। এইচএসসি/সমমান পাশ হইতে হইবে। খ। সংশ্লিষ্ট কাজে ৩ বছরের অভিজ্ঞতা থাকিতে হইবে; গ। সংশ্লিষ্ট বিষয়ে যোগ্য ও অভিজ্ঞ প্রার্থীদের ক্ষেত্রে বয়সসীমা শিথিলযোগ্য।
৯।	ক্যাটালগার ০১ (এক) টি, স্থায়ী পদ (গ্রেড-১৪) ১০,২০০-২৪,৬৮০/- ৩২ বৎসর	ক। কোনো স্বীকৃত বিশ্ববিদ্যালয় হইতে স্নাতক ডিগ্রি/সংশ্লিষ্ট বিষয়ে ডিপ্লোমাধারী; খ। সংশ্লিষ্ট কাজে অভিজ্ঞতা সম্পন্ন প্রার্থী অগ্রাধিকারযোগ্য; গ। সংশ্লিষ্ট বিষয়ে যোগ্য ও অভিজ্ঞ প্রার্থীদের ক্ষেত্রে বয়সসীমা শিথিলযোগ্য।
১০।	অফিস সহকারী কাম কম্পিউটার টাইপিস্ট ০১ (এক) টি, স্থায়ী পদ (গ্রেড-১৬) ৯,৩০০-২২,৪৯০/- ৩২ বৎসর	ক। কোনো স্বীকৃত বোর্ড হইতে উচ্চ মাধ্যমিক সার্টিফিকেট বা সমমানের পরীক্ষায় উত্তীর্ণ; খ। কম্পিউটার ব্যবহারে দক্ষতা এবং গ। টাইপিং এ প্রতি মিনিটে বাংলায় ২০ ইংরেজিতে ২০ শব্দের গতি এবং নিয়োগকারী কর্তৃপক্ষ কর্তৃক গৃহীত স্ট্যান্ডার্ড অ্যাপটিচিউট টেস্টে উত্তীর্ণ এবং অফিস পরিচালনা সংক্রান্ত বিভিন্ন কম্পিউটার ব্যবহারিক প্রোগ্রাম যেমন- এমএস ওয়ার্ড, এক্সেল ও পাওয়ার পয়েন্ট ইত্যাদি বিষয়ে দক্ষ হইতে হইবে; ঘ। কোনো পাবলিক বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়/সরকারি/আধা-সরকারি/স্বায়ত্বশাসিত প্রতিষ্ঠানে ফটোকপি অপারেটর/ডেচপাচ রাইডার/সমমানের পদে চাকুরীরত প্রার্থীদের অগ্রাধিকার দেওয়া হইবে।
১১।	ল্যাব অ্যাটেনড্যান্ট ০৩ (তিন) টি, স্থায়ী পদ (গ্রেড-১৯) ৮,৫০০-২০,৫৭০/- ৩২ বৎসর	ক। এইচএসসি বা সমমান (বিজ্ঞান) পরীক্ষায় পাশ হইতে হইবে। খ। সংশ্লিষ্ট কাজে অভিজ্ঞতাসম্পন্ন প্রার্থীদের অগ্রাধিকার দেওয়া হইবে।
১২।	অফিস সহায়ক ০৩ (তিন) টি, স্থায়ী পদ (গ্রেড-২০) ৮,২৫০-২০,০১০/- ৩২ বৎসর	ক। এসএসসি বা সমমান পরীক্ষায় উত্তীর্ণ; খ। সংশ্লিষ্ট কাজে অভিজ্ঞতাসম্পন্ন প্রার্থীদের অগ্রাধিকার দেওয়া হইবে এবং বয়সসীমা শিথিলযোগ্য।

আবেদনের শর্তাবলী:

১। আগ্রহী প্রার্থীদের আবেদনপত্র ৩০ আগষ্ট ২০২৬ তারিখের মধ্যে রেজিস্ট্রার, অ্যাভিয়েশন অ্যান্ড অ্যারোস্পেস বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়, বাংলাদেশ, পুরাতন বিমানবন্দর, তেজগাঁও, ঢাকা-১২১৫ ঠিকানায় (সরকারি ছুটির দিন ব্যতীত অফিস চলাকালীন সময়ে) ডাকযোগে/সরাসরি রেজিস্ট্রার অফিসে অথবা estb@aaub.edu.bd ই-মেইল ঠিকানায় পৌঁছাতে হবে। আবেদন ফরম অত্র বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়ের ওয়েবসাইট www.aaub.edu.bd বা রেজিস্ট্রার অফিস হতে সংগ্রহ করা যাবে। প্রার্থীর পদের নাম খামের উপর/ই-মেইল ঠিকানায় স্পষ্টাক্ষরে উল্লেখ করতে হবে। ডাকযোগে/সরাসরি পাঠানো আবেদনপত্রের সাথে প্রার্থীর যোগাযোগের ঠিকানাসহ ১০ টাকার ডাকটিকিট সম্বলিত ফেরত খাম সংযুক্ত করিতে হইবে।

২। অ্যাভিয়েশন অ্যান্ড অ্যারোস্পেস বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়, বাংলাদেশ (এএইউবি) এর অনুকূলে যে কোনো তফসিলি ব্যাংক হতে ৯ম গ্রেড বা তদূর্ধ্ব ২০০.০০ (দুইশত) টাকা, ১১তম গ্রেড ১৫০.০০ (একশত পঞ্চাশ) টাকা, ১৩তম-১৬তম গ্রেড-১০০.০০ (একশত) টাকা ও ১৯তম-২০তম গ্রেড ৫০.০০ (পঞ্চাশ) টাকা মূল্যের পে-অর্ডার/ব্যাংক ড্রাফট (অফেরতযোগ্য) আবেদনপত্রের সাথে সংযুক্ত করতে হবে। আবেদনপত্রে ব্যাংক ড্রাফট/পে-অর্ডার নম্বর, ব্যাংকের নাম, শাখা, টাকার পরিমান ও তারিখ উল্লেখ করতে হবে। ই-মেইল ঠিকানায় প্রেরিত আবেদনপত্রের সাথে পে-অর্ডার/ব্যাংক ড্রাফট এর স্ক্যানকপি এবং প্রার্থীর সদ্যতোলা পাসপোর্ট সাইজের ০১ (এক) কপি রঙিন ছবি সংযুক্ত করতে হবে এবং পে-অর্ডার/ব্যাংক ড্রাফট এর মূলকপি আবেদনপত্রের মূলকপির সাথে ডাকযোগে/সরাসরি উল্লেখিত ঠিকানায় প্রেরণ করিতে হইবে।

৩। প্রার্থীকে আবেদনপত্রের সাথে সদ্যতোলা পাসপোর্ট সাইজের ০৩ (তিন) কপি রঙিন সত্যায়িত ছবি, সকল শিক্ষাগত যোগ্যতার সনদপত্র ও নম্বরপত্রের সত্যায়িত অনুলিপি, অভিজ্ঞতার সনদের সত্যায়িত অনুলিপি, জাতীয় পরিচয়পত্রের সত্যায়িত অনুলিপি এবং বিদেশী বিশ্ববিদ্যালয় হতে অর্জিত ডিগ্রীর ক্ষেত্রে বাংলাদেশ বিশ্ববিদ্যালয় মঞ্জুরী কমিশন হতে ইস্যুকৃত সমমান সনদের সত্যায়িত অনুলিপি জমাদান করতে হবে। ই-মেইল ঠিকানায় প্রেরিত আবেদনপত্রের সাথে উল্লেখিত সনদসমূহের স্ক্যানকপি সংযুক্ত করতে হবে। মৌখিক পরীক্ষার সময় সকল কাগজপত্রের মূলকপি প্রদর্শন করিতে হইবে।

৪। মুক্তিযোদ্ধা, শহীদ মুক্তিযোদ্ধা ও বীরাঙ্গনার সন্তানদের কোটার ক্ষেত্রে মুক্তিযুদ্ধ বিষয়ক মন্ত্রণালয়ের সংশ্লিষ্ট কর্মকর্তা কর্তৃক স্বাক্ষরিত সনদের সত্যায়িত কপি এবং ক্ষুদ্র নৃ-গোষ্ঠী, শারীরিক প্রতিবন্ধী ও তৃতীয় লিঙ্গের কোটার ক্ষেত্রে সংশ্লিষ্ট কর্তৃপক্ষ কর্তৃক প্রদত্ত সনদের সত্যায়িত কপি জমাদান করিতে হইবে।

৫। ৩০ আগষ্ট ২০২৬ তারিখে প্রার্থীর বয়সসীমা সর্বোচ্চ সীমার মধ্যে থাকিতে হইবে।

৬। চাকুরীরত যোগ্য প্রার্থীগণকে যথাযথ কর্তৃপক্ষের মাধ্যমে অনুমোদন গ্রহণ করতঃ নির্ধারিত সময়সীমার মধ্যে আবেদন করিতে হইবে।

৭। অত্র বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়ের অধ্যয়নের মাধ্যম ইংরেজি বিধায় কর্মকর্তা পদের প্রার্থীদের ক্ষেত্রে ইংরেজিতে পারদর্শী হইতে হইবে।

৮। জাতীয় বেতন-স্কেল ২০১৫ অনুযায়ী বেতন-স্কেল উল্লেখ করা হইয়াছে। তবে সরকার কর্তৃক সময়ে সময়ে জারিকৃত জাতীয় বেতন-স্কেল বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়ের জন্যও সমভাবে প্রযোজ্য হইবে।

৯। আবেদনকালে প্রার্থীকে অবশ্যই সংশ্লিষ্ট বিষয়ে ডিগ্রিপ্রাপ্ত হইতে হইবে। অর্থাৎ পরীক্ষার ফল প্রকাশ অপেক্ষমান থাকাকালীন সময়ে আবেদন গ্রহণযোগ্য হইবে না।

১০। নির্ধারিত তফসিল অনুযায়ী সকল পদের লিখিত (প্রযোজ্য ক্ষেত্রে), ব্যবহারিক (প্রযোজ্য ক্ষেত্রে) ও মৌখিক পরীক্ষা অনুষ্ঠিত হইবে। লিখিত/ব্যবহারিক/মৌখিক/অন্য কোন পরীক্ষায় অংশগ্রহণের জন্য কোন প্রকার টিএ/ডিএ/ভাতা প্রদান করা হইবে না।

১১। বিজ্ঞপ্তি নংঃ এএইউবি/রেজিস্ট্রার-১৫৬/২০২৫/১০ তারিখঃ ২৭ এপ্রিল ২০২৫ এ প্রকাশিত নিয়োগ বিজ্ঞপ্তিতে সহকারী পরিচালক পদে এবং এএইউবি/রেজিস্ট্রার-১৫৬/২০২৬/খন্ড-০১/২৯ তারিখঃ ০৭ মে ২০২৬ এ প্রকাশিত নিয়োগ বিজ্ঞপ্তিতে যারা আবেদন করেছিলেন তাদের পুনরায় এই নিয়োগ বিজ্ঞপ্তির সংশ্লিষ্ট পদে আবেদন করার প্রয়োজন নেই। তাদের পূর্বের আবেদনই গ্রহণযোগ্য বলে বিবেচিত হইবে।

১২। সকল প্রকার নিয়োগের ক্ষেত্রে সরকারি বিধি-বিধান ও বাংলাদেশ বিশ্ববিদ্যালয় মঞ্জুরী কমিশন কর্তৃক সর্বশেষ জারিকৃত নির্দেশনা অনুসরণ করা হইবে।

১৩। আবেদন শুরুর তারিখ: ০৮ আগষ্ট ২০২৬ এবং আবেদন জমাদানের শেষ তারিখ: ৩০ আগষ্ট ২০২৬ পর্যন্ত।

১৪। লিখিত (প্রযোজ্য ক্ষেত্রে), ব্যবহারিক (প্রযোজ্য ক্ষেত্রে) ও মৌখিক পরীক্ষার তারিখ অত্র বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়ের ওয়েবসাইট (www.aaub.edu.bd) এর মাধ্যমে জানানো হইবে।

১৫। নিয়োগকৃত পদে নিয়োগ ও চাকরির ক্ষেত্রে সরকার কর্তৃক সর্বশেষ জারিকৃত বিধি-বিধান প্রযোজ্য হইবে।

১৬। নিয়োগের ক্ষেত্রে সরকারের সর্বশেষ কোটা নীতি ও পদ্ধতি অনুসরণ করা হইবে।

১৭। বিভাগীয় প্রার্থীদের ক্ষেত্রে উচ্চতর পদে আবেদনের জন্য বয়সসীমা প্রযোজ্য নহে।

১৮। নিয়োগ বিজ্ঞপ্তিটি অত্র বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়ের ওয়েব সাইটে (www.aaub.edu.bd) পাওয়া যাইবে।

১৯। কেবলমাত্র যোগ্য প্রার্থীদের নির্ধারিত তারিখে লিখিত পরীক্ষা (প্রযোজ্য ক্ষেত্রে) গ্রহণ করা হইবে এবং লিখিত পরীক্ষায় উত্তীর্ণ প্রার্থীগণ ব্যবহারিক (প্রযোজ্য ক্ষেত্রে) ও মৌখিক পরীক্ষায় অংশগ্রহণ করিবেন।

২০। কোনো কারণ দর্শানো ব্যতিরেকে বিশ্ববিদ্যালয় কর্তৃপক্ষ নিয়োগ প্রক্রিয়া স্থগিত/বাতিল/প্রত্যাহার করার ক্ষমতা সংরক্ষণ করে।

২১। নিয়োগের ক্ষেত্রে কর্তৃপক্ষের সিদ্ধান্তই চূড়ান্ত বলিয়া গণ্য হইবে।

২২। অসম্পূর্ণ, ত্রুটিপূর্ণ, ভূল তথ্য সম্বলিত অথবা বিলম্বে প্রাপ্ত আবেদনসমূহ বাতিল বলিয়া গণ্য হইবে। আবেদনপত্রের উপর যেকোনো ধরণের সুপারিশ প্রার্থীর অযোগ্যতা হিসাবে গণ্য হইবে। আবেদনপত্র গ্রহণ অথবা বাতিল করিবার ক্ষেত্রে কর্তৃপক্ষের সিদ্ধান্তই চূড়ান্ত বলিয়া গণ্য হইবে।

Sajjad Hossain 06.08.26

রেজিস্ট্রার
অ্যাভিয়েশন অ্যান্ড অ্যারোস্পেস বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়, বাংলাদেশ

GD-1910

Ukraine hits Wildberries site in Russia

Fire reported; drones strike agricultural warehouses in eastern Ukraine

AGENCIES

Ukrainian drones hit a warehouse belonging to Russian e-commerce giant Wildberries hundreds of miles from the frontline yesterday, the latest in a series of attacks on its facilities.

"Firefighters have been deployed to the company's logistics centre in Yekaterinburg... where a fire broke out as a result of an attack," Wildberries said in a statement, adding that all staff had been moved to safety.

Regional governor Denis Pasler said three drones crashed into the roof of the warehouse early yesterday without causing any



casualties in the city, more than 2,000 kilometres from the border with Ukraine.

Since mid-July, Ukraine has struck around 20 sites belonging to Wildberries, an online retail platform often described as Russia's Amazon, reports AFP.

Meanwhile, Russian drone strikes caused a fire at an agricultural company's warehouses in the Balakliia community in eastern Ukraine's Kharkiv region, local authorities said on Telegram, not naming the facility but adding that there were no casualties.

President Volodymyr Zelensky on Thursday promised to provide support to farmers hit by Russian attacks. Moscow has recently moved to strike Ukraine's agricultural export facilities and commercial vessels in the Black Sea region.

Meanwhile, Russian President Vladimir Putin discussed the situation in the Gulf and Ukraine with United Arab Emirates President Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan during a phone call, the Kremlin said yesterday.

It said Putin had expressed his gratitude to the United Arab Emirates for its role in organising exchanges of prisoners of war and detainees between Russia and Ukraine.



Migrants, including minors, queue for food from a local NGO in Ceuta, Spain, Thursday, after mass crossings from Morocco. Spanish police and forensic experts yesterday brought in extra staff to identify 80 bodies found after the rush, as families await news of missing loved ones.

PHOTO: REUTERS

IRAN WAR DILEMMA

Trump stuck with no exit in sight

Analysts say emerging Iran-Oman deal on Hormuz would offer major concession to Tehran

REUTERS, *Washington*

With President Donald Trump's war against Iran now in its sixth month, a mix of threats and diplomacy has underscored the bind he faces in trying to end a conflict he once claimed would last weeks.

Trump is caught between backing an interim deal being negotiated by Iran and Oman that could give Tehran new authority over the Strait of Hormuz, or escalating with fresh airstrikes that risk prolonging the crisis. Analysts say the first option would hand Iran its biggest concession

Trump's political risks with midterms looming: high gas prices, low approval ratings

since the war began in February, while the second could carry political peril ahead of November's US midterms.

Maintaining the uneasy status quo — a blockade of Iran's ports and periodic retaliation — offers no clear exit either. "It's a menu of bad options," said Aaron David Miller, a former US negotiator, noting Trump may have to accept a new Iranian reality in the strait.

A US official told Reuters any "temporary" shipping routes



would remain open without oversight. Yet Secretary of State Marco Rubio insists the strait must stay an international waterway free of Iranian control. Trump has contradicted Rubio before, and analysts warn he could again.

High gasoline prices, low approval ratings, and public opposition to the war have narrowed Trump's room to maneuver.

His threats have failed to force Iran to yield, raising the likelihood that Washington may compromise. Reopening the strait is seen as essential for renewed talks on Iran's nuclear program, though experts doubt a final peace deal is near.

Iranian sources say proposed terms would give Tehran some control over Gulf shipping. Trump has suggested a deal is imminent, but Iranian officials say details remain unresolved. Even if talks resume, skepticism persists after a June memorandum unraveled.

Trump canceled new strikes after regional partners urged diplomacy, but warned of harsher action if talks fail.

Analysts note concerns about US missile stockpiles may also have influenced his decision. Iran has threatened retaliation against Gulf allies if attacked again.

With midterms looming, Trump faces a war that has achieved few of its goals. "The Islamic Republic is trying to force Trump into a lose-lose proposition," said Behnam Ben Taleblu of the Foundation for the Defense of Democracies.

SECURITY THREAT

Pak-controlled Kashmir defers some polls

AFP, *Islamabad*

Polling in two districts of disputed Pakistan-administered Kashmir has been postponed because of security concerns, the election commission said yesterday, days before voting was due to take place.

The third phase of elections was scheduled for August 10, but polling in Poonch and Palandri has been postponed, the commission said.

"A new date and revised schedule will be announced after reviewing the situation," it added.

The postponement comes after unrest was sparked by demands to abolish 12 seats in the local legislature reserved for people who migrated from the Indian-administered portion of Kashmir.

The movement was led by the Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC), which the government banned under anti-terrorism laws.

The government also instructed international media to seek permission to report outside major cities after foreign news organisations covered protests, elections in Kashmir.

The information minister and the ministry's media wing did not immediately respond to AFP's questions.

US sanctions Cuban armed forces minister

Military procurement network also targeted

AFP, *Washington*

The United States announced new sanctions on Thursday that target Cuban Armed Forces Minister General Alvaro Lopez Miera, seven other individuals and five state-owned entities over their alleged role in foreign arms procurement.

"These actions target state-owned entities, military enterprises, and Ministry of the Revolutionary Armed Forces (MINFAR) officials involved in foreign military cooperation and the procurement of military equipment intended for the Cuban regime," the US State Department said.

The other individuals sanctioned include the chief of general staff of the Cuban armed forces, the heads of the military's foreign relations and economic wings, and its military attaches to China and Russia.

The state-linked entities targeted by the new sanctions are alleged to aid in Cuban procurement of weapons from countries deemed to be US adversaries, including China and Russia.

"These designations follow the Department's July 20 report 'Cuba: The Capital of 21st Century Communism,' which chronicles Cuban regime's continuing partnerships with Russia and China, both of which have supplied Cuba with military hardware, surveillance technologies, and other security capabilities," the State Department said.

Bomb on minibus near Damascus wounded 14: Syria

REUTERS

A bomb planted in a minibus wounded 14 people on the outskirts of Syria's capital Damascus on Thursday night, with some of the injuries so severe that they were taken for fatalities, an official said yesterday.

Officials had said on Thursday that two people were killed in the blast. Health ministry head of media, Riad al-Sayed Hasan, told Reuters that assessment was based on the discovery of body parts at the scene which turned out to be those of some of the people severely wounded.

The blast occurred in the predominantly Druze area of Jaramana, outside Damascus. A security source told the state-run Ekhbariya TV that the blast was caused by an explosive device planted on the vehicle, citing preliminary information.



Footage from the scene showed the blown-up husk of a white minibus being dragged away from the site of the blast.

Authorities have not blamed anyone for the attack, which took place in an area where there have been clashes between the Druze and Islamist militants backing the authorities that took over after the overthrow of President Bashar al-Assad in 2024.

Jaramana resident Samer Abbas was metres away in his clothing store when the explosion went off. A piece of shrapnel hit the storefront.

"It was a strong, unnatural sound," he told Reuters. His son had been sitting outside. Fearing the worst, Abbas said he could not breathe until he confirmed he was safe.

"My blood dried up until I checked up on him, I saw him ... until I heard his voice," he said.

'No need to worry, I'm with you'

Indian PM tells Trinamool rebels, ex-Uddhav Sena MPs

AGENCIES

Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi held a breakfast meeting with newly elected NDA Lok Sabha MPs amid the ongoing ruckus in Parliament, urging them to actively participate in the parliamentary debates.

Around 45 MPs, including seven from the Shiv Sena, 20 from the National Citizens Party of India (NCPI), and two from the NCP (Ajit Pawar), were present at the meeting yesterday.

Modi also assured the Trinamool rebels and the six former Shiv Sena (Uddhav camp) MPs, who recently joined the Eknath Shinde Sena, that he is "with them" and they had "nothing to worry about".

"The NDA is a family. We are with the constituent parties. Every individual will be respected and given a chance. I am with every MP, not just one constituent party of the NDA. I stand with every MP of the NDA. You don't need to worry about anyone," he said.

The PM further urged them to use their power effectively to advance development projects in their constituencies. He also told the MPs to read, learn, and understand the history of Parliament, reports NDTV online.

"There is a wealth of historical material in Parliament; use it to prepare debates. Work for the development of your respective states. The country will progress only when states progress," he said.

"Contact the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) directly for any development work in your area...Meet everyone, including poor labourers and farmers, and understand everyone's problems," he said.



Sri Lanka's Special Task Force and police patrol amid a riot at Pallansena open prison yesterday, during a stand-off between inmates and guards. Troops were later deployed to Colombo's maximum-security prison and two other jails after failed breakout attempts left three inmates dead and 23 wounded, a minister said.

PHOTO: AFP

TEEN HEALTH FUND

Meta ordered to pay $567m in New Mexico

REUTERS

A New Mexico state court ordered Meta on Thursday to pay $567 million into a teen mental health fund and change how its platforms function for young users after finding the company is to blame for harming children's wellbeing.

Judge Bryan Biedscheid in Santa Fe ruled the company had created a public nuisance in New Mexico, siding with Attorney General Raúl Torrez, a Democrat. Torrez had accused the social media company of designing products to addict young users and failing to protect children from sexual exploitation on its platforms.

The ruling comes five months after a New Mexico jury in an earlier phase of the case ordered Meta to pay $375 million after finding it violated consumer protection law.

The Daily Star
FOUNDER EDITOR: **LATE S. M. ALI**

Govt must prioritise road safety

Address systemic failures behind recurring road fatalities

It is deeply distressing to see how road crashes continue to take lives across the country, with the authorities who are supposed to ensure road safety appearing indifferent to the crisis. According to the latest Road Safety Foundation (RSF) report, at least 416 people were killed and 629 others injured in 458 crashes across Bangladesh in July this year. The latest incident reported took place at daybreak on August 7: in Bogura, seven people died and several others were injured when a speeding bus lost control and ploughed into them. Such tragedies have become horrifyingly frequent, and the saddest part is that most of them are preventable.

The causes behind these fatal crashes are all too familiar: unfit vehicles, poor road conditions, speeding, reckless and unskilled driving, excessive working hours for drivers, weak traffic management, and dangerous motorcycle riding, among others. Motorcycle crashes alone claimed 138 lives in July, accounting for about one-third of all road-related deaths. Dhaka division recorded the highest number of crashes and fatalities, while 164 accidents occurred after drivers lost control of their vehicles. Another recent RSF analysis found that, between 2020 and July 2026, Dhaka alone saw at least 1,384 people killed and 2,488 injured in 1,849 road crashes. Pedestrians and motorcyclists together accounted for more than 80 percent of these fatalities. In the capital, inadequate road capacity, mixed traffic, encroached footpaths, poorly designed footbridges, and the lack of bypass roads that force heavy vehicles to pass through the city at night are among the key factors behind road crashes. What's worse, prolonged traffic congestion fuels impatience and aggressive driving, further increasing the risk of crashes.

Following the deadly crash in Bogura, local residents demanded speed breakers at the accident site, which the authorities assured would be installed. While this is a welcome step, acting only after precious lives have been lost is not the way to improve road safety. Instead, the authorities must implement a comprehensive road safety strategy. Hazardous locations across the road network should be identified and made safer before they become sites of recurring tragedy. It is also quite baffling that, despite road crashes being a regular occurrence in the country, government agencies still don't maintain a uniform database on such incidents. How can they formulate effective policies or prevent road deaths without reliable official data?

Road crashes are the direct result of policy failures, weak enforcement of law, and institutional negligence. The government must demonstrate its political will to fully implement the Road Transport Act, 2018, carry out long-overdue reforms in the sector, strengthen the monitoring of dangerous driving, remove unfit vehicles from the roads, improve road engineering, and ensure effective coordination among the agencies responsible for transport management. Until road safety is treated as a national priority, our streets will continue to claim lives that should never have been lost.

Jhum's decline must be taken seriously

Shrinking jhum lands reflect failure in protecting Indigenous livelihood

Ahead of the International Day of the World's Indigenous Peoples on August 9, which raises awareness of Indigenous rights and cultures worldwide, we must recognise the challenges such communities face in our country. According to a report by *Prothom Alo*, jhum cultivation, one of the central ways of Indigenous life in our country, has shrunken across Bandarban, Rangamati and Khagrachhari in recent years. Many jhum farmers have moved to fruit farming as an alternative.

Traditional jhum is a multi-crop system where rice, vegetables, pulses, spices, and other crops are grown together. For many farmers, treating the land with respect is central to jhum cultivation, and it is embedded in their identity and culture. It is particularly convenient in the hills as it doesn't require a large irrigation system, heavy agricultural machinery, or substantial capital. This farming method has unique advantages because the polycultural approach can make crops more resilient to pests and climate shocks. The controlled use of fire in jhum cultivation is often used as a criticism. But when practised with adequate fallow periods and the burning is carefully managed, it becomes part of a rotational cycle, allowing the soil to regenerate over time. The length of the fallow period, however, is crucial to traditional jhum as shortening it weakens forest regeneration, depletes soil fertility, and undermines biodiversity.

A question that now naturally occurs is: why is such an age-old agricultural practice, which remains central to the livelihoods of so many residents of the Chittagong Hill Tract (CHT) region, being allowed to wither away? And perhaps a more concerning question is why there have not been adequate government initiatives to understand jhum cultivation and its significance.

Indeed, several factors played a role in the decline of jhum lands. For instance, the Kaptai hydroelectric dam across the Karnaphuli River submerged vast valleys and farmlands. This, along with commercial monocultural plantations, land encroachments, and climate change, contributed to the loss of jhum plots. However, this decline cannot be separated from the unresolved Indigenous question in Bangladesh. Nearly three decades after the CHT Accord was signed, some of its key provisions on land rights and local governance remain unimplemented. What has emerged instead is a trend of mindless development both in the CHT and beyond.

Therefore, we urge the authorities to ensure that jhum cultivation is recognised and treated as valuable ancestral knowledge. In cases where jhum is no longer considered viable, those whose lives and livelihoods depend on such farming must be justly transitioned into other agricultural practices. We also urge the government to be serious about protecting Indigenous rights and ensure that development in the hills strengthens, rather than erases, the ecological and cultural heritage of the CHT.

The fine line between moral courage and entitlement

BLOWIN' IN THE WIND



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SHAMSAD MORTUZA

Do I have the right, or the moral courage, to call a spade a spade? Images of a student leader confronting and beating his party opponents with a spade in front of teachers and university administration made me reflect on the instruments of obedience that have been inculcated in us with an effect of silence. These student leaders fought against arbitrary power and helped the older generation acknowledge its failures, such as tolerating compromised elections and weakened institutions while preferring institutional stability through silence. But in the post-uprising scenario, we have also realised that overthrowing authority and building democracy are two different matters. The urgency, solidarity and disruption that accompanied the toppling of the previous regime must change the rules for restoring democracy. For that, we need a different set of values: patience, room for disagreement, and institutional restraint. And above all, there has to be the willingness to accept that no generation possesses the whole truth. And there is no shortcut to knowledge.

It is unfortunate that we are seeing a culture where moral power is exercised arbitrarily, where accusation precedes evidence and power precedes procedure. Students are deciding who could teach, who must apologise, and which political associations are permissible. Some of this anger is valid. Partisan appointments, patronage, and teachers' silence during repression have damaged the profession's moral standing. But public humiliation and collective punishment reproduced the very logic of the former authoritarian rule the uprising opposed.

It is unfortunate that we are seeing a culture where moral power is exercised arbitrarily, where accusation precedes evidence and power precedes procedure. Students are deciding who could teach, who must apologise, and which political associations are permissible.

A wise philosopher once said, "Revolution devours its children." The pandemonium we are witnessing across campuses is a reminder of the paradox that Milton's Satan faced after challenging the existing hierarchy. Unwittingly, he created an alternative hierarchy where that question became, "Did we reject arbitrary authority, or did we merely change who is entitled to exercise it?"



VISUAL: **STAR**

As a student of literature, I am no stranger to disobedience as a cultural theme. In Sophocles' play, the daughter of King Oedipus, Antigone, defies the state law to bury her dead brother in defiance of the king's decree. For her, the divine law of respecting the dead and the duty of standing by a family member matter the most. Antigone shows us that defiance alone is not an ethic; it becomes ethical only when it submits itself to a principle larger than the defiant individual. We hailed the students for showing us the big picture. So it pains us to see how these students have now gotten entangled in reproducing some of the old cruelties. Sporadic violence across campuses to assert political dominance is one instance of that. Has our youthful agency become youthful absolutism?

We are seeing the growing sentiment that views "we were right" as "we are always right." History tells us that political courage in one historical moment does not confer permanent epistemic authority. My students, who have returned to the classrooms after the uprising, recognise that being able to identify an injustice does not automatically provide the knowledge needed to run a university or to reform a curriculum. Managing an economy or constructing a constitutional democracy is not an AI prompt that can yield ready-made solutions.

The power with which our student leaders claimed, "We did it," must also recognise the power of the first-person plural. The beauty of democracy demands that "we" remain open enough to include people who disagree with us.

Once again, we return to the fall of a seemingly immovable regime within weeks. Two alternative versions are competing for legitimacy: one group is saying that we simmered the rice pot to a boiling point over 15 and a half years, while the other group is saying that we cooked the rice in just a few weeks. Our memory is long enough to know that a shortcut is not always the best method. The uprising can unintentionally encourage the belief that every difficult structure can be bypassed: the government through the streets, expertise through confidence, education through artificial intelligence, and employment through a start-up pitch.

Now that we have a settled, democratically elected government, we need to resort to some policy interventions to shift the mindset. From the top, we must send a clear message: becoming ready for democracy takes time. Becoming ready for the job market requires time. The disrespect for individual teachers is also reflected in the disregard for the institutions. Our policymakers must restore faith in the educational institutions. Heroics through violence are compromising the very purpose of education.

We need to return to the fundamentals of education: that required reading takes time. Knowledge can only be attained through repetition. We cannot expect all our graduates to become entrepreneurs overnight. "Be your own boss" can be a glamorous escape from apprenticeship, disciplinary knowledge and accountability. A business requires solid foundations in accounting, governance and persistence. The tendency to pursue shortcuts is leading to a path filled with short-term success. The same goes for modern technology; AI, for instance, can accelerate thought but can also create the appearance of competence without substance. With so much discourse on change and reform, we must not delete institutional memory or the human knowledge base that we have.

Then again, we need to be aware of corrupt teachers with compromised morality. However, a rotten apple does not necessarily spoil a teaching "barrel," just like a naughty parliamentarian does not make parliamentary democracy obsolete. Institutions preserve rights precisely because individuals—including heroic individuals—are fallible. Due process protects not only the accused but also the accuser from the eventual misuse of precedent. If students can remove a teacher today without investigation, another political group can use the same method against a principled teacher tomorrow.

The agency and entitlement that we see pervading our system, along with the tendency to take shortcuts that affect our mindset, are creating social tensions and frictions. The children of revolution must be aware of the trap that gives the false impression that they have assumed a privileged position from which they can proclaim what is right and what is wrong. The same goes for us, the older generation, who also have been ambivalent and lost some of our agency.

One can argue whether, in a post-truth era, it is really possible to discern the truth from untruth and right from wrong. Then again, where do we garner the courage to call the spade a spade? The clash of students across campuses makes me wonder.

Customer confidence is crucial for a functioning cashless economy



Milon Kumar Dash
is senior officer at Sonali Bank PLC.

MILON KUMAR DASH

The Bangladesh Bank (BB) has embarked on an ambitious journey to fundamentally alter how crores of citizens spend, save and transfer money. Over the past decade, the rapid expansion of mobile financial services (MFS), internet banking, and digital infrastructure has altered the landscape. Despite that, the country remains anchored to a cash-dominated reality.

The structural obstacle is a complex gridlock of economic friction, digital illiteracy, and deep-seated consumer mistrust. To achieve the central bank's definitive roadmap—which mandates that 75 percent of national retail transactions be settled digitally by July 2027 before transitioning to a fully cashless economy by 2031—policymakers must recognise that technology alone cannot change human behaviour. The transition requires an aggressive regulatory shift that makes digital architecture demonstrably cheaper, safer, and more universally accessible.

The rapid promotion of Bangla QR, which has scaled to an impressive 9.63 lakh registered merchant outlets facilitating nearly 66 lakh transactions, stands as a testament to the institutional push. Under the latest directives, the Bangladesh Bank has mandated that all commercial banking and MFS providers replace their proprietary, siloed QR codes with this unified, interoperable standard. Furthermore, the continuous deployment of the National Payment Switch Bangladesh (NPSB) and the open-source Instant Payment System (IIPS) aim to eliminate transaction barriers across fragmented financial networks. Still, a contradiction persists: why would a rational citizen abandon cash if the digital alternative comes at a cost? A retail landscape where cash remains completely free to pass from hand to hand will always outperform a digital ecosystem that charges fees for every transaction.

To unlock the stagnant potential, the central bank must transition to a true "zero fee" framework. First, interbank ATM withdrawals, which currently cost up to Tk 30 for high-value transactions, must be entirely free of cost. The current NPSB interoperability levies, encompassing the 0.15 percent fee for bank-to-MFS transfers and the steep 0.85 percent tax on cross-MFS and merchant settlements, must be fully subsidised or removed. Second, small-scale retailers and micro-merchants using Bangla QR must be completely exempted from any settlement fees or cash-out charges when handling supply chain costs. Third, institutional rewards and remittance-style incentives must be ensured. Mirroring the highly successful 2.5 percent state incentive for remittances, the government should introduce a 2 to 3 percent direct cashback or sovereign tax rebate for consumers who use digital payment channels for utilities, mass public transit, and essential commodities.

Fourth, small traders and street vendors who actively settle transactions through digital means should be granted multi-year corporate tax holidays alongside automated eligibility for low-interest nano-loans. Fifth, a vast portion of the rural populace remains unable to navigate complex authentication workflows, smartphone user interfaces, and mobile banking applications. The state must mobilise its extensive network of union digital centres (UDCs) to host community-based financial training bootcamps. Meanwhile, financial literacy and cyber safety frameworks must be formally integrated into the secondary and higher secondary national academic curricula.

No variable in the cashless equation is more vital than consumer confidence. Consumers will often tolerate minor transactional delays, but they are unlikely to tolerate the lingering fear that their lives' savings could be compromised in an instant. Studies by the Bangladesh Institute of Bank Management (BIBM) confirm that fear of cyber fraud, sophisticated SMS phishing, and identity theft remain the primary deterrents to digital migration.

Encouragingly, some institutions have demonstrated that risk mitigation is entirely achievable. Many commercial entities have significantly fortified the security architecture, incorporating rigid device-binding protocols, universal multi-layered OTP verification, and compulsory biometric authentication safeguarding crores of digital consumers. To formalise this level of defence across the entire industry, the central bank must mandate universal fingerprint or facial verification protocols before the authorisation of any high-value transactional transfer, and the immediate establishment of a digital consumer protection fund to guarantee rapid, full financial reimbursement for victims of institutional cybercrime.

The transition towards a cashless society is far more than a technical upgrade; it is a fundamental reconfiguration of the social contract between the state, the financial apparatus, and the citizens. If executed with systemic empathy, a digitised economy will radically suppress structural corruption, lower cash handling expenses, optimise tax transparency, and formalise the massive parallel informal economy. However, that future will remain elusive unless the concerns of ordinary consumers are prioritised over the profitability of financial intermediaries.

The Daily Star Reg. No. DA 781
EDITOR & PUBLISHER: Mahfuz Anam Printed by him on behalf of Mediaworld Ltd at Transcraft Ltd, 229, Tejgaon Industrial Area, editor@thedailystar.net
Registered & Head Offices: The Daily Star Centre 64-65 Kazi Nazrul Islam Avenue, Dhaka-1215 Phone: 09610222222
Newsroom: Fax- 58156306 reporting@thedailystar.net
Advertisement: 01711623910 advertisement@thedailystar.net GPO Box: 3257
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A dual strategy of ecological restoration and smart forecasting for flood resilience

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Flooding is inseparable from Bangladesh's identity. For centuries, the country has been shaped by rivers as monsoon water spread across floodplains, replenished wetlands, and drained through a vast network of rivers, canals, beels, and haors. However, while floods are natural, the growing destruction they cause is not. Climate variability is making floods harder to anticipate, but climate alone cannot explain why water increasingly becomes trapped around homes, roads, and farmland. Over the years, people have occupied floodplains, filled wetlands, blocked canals, and built roads and embankments across natural flow paths. We are steadily removing the places where floodwater once went.

Research by the University of Texas at Arlington found that nearly 600,000 square kilometres of natural floodplains were converted to agricultural and urban land worldwide between 1992 and 2019—an area about four times the size of Bangladesh. When a floodplain is filled or disconnected from a river through unplanned development, its storage capacity does not disappear without consequences: water rises higher upstream, moves faster through narrow openings, remains trapped longer, or is redirected towards communities that were previously less exposed.

The country now needs a two-part strategy: i) protect and restore its floodplains, canal networks, and native haor wetlands; and ii) build a new generation of impact-based early warning system using AI, hydrological models, and local observations blended with the latest satellite data. One cannot succeed without the other.

Major cities in Bangladesh are already showing what happens when natural water storage areas and drainage pathways are lost. In Dhaka and Chattogram, the filling of low-lying land, wetlands, ponds, and canals has left stormwater with fewer places to go. As a result, even moderate rainfall can overwhelm drainage systems, and streets turn into waterways, homes become islands, and floodwater takes much longer to recede.

The same pattern is increasingly threatening the haors of Sylhet and Sunamganj. Haors are among the country's most important natural flood management systems. During the dry season, haors support rice production, fisheries, and livestock grazing. During the monsoon, these depressions receive rainwater and become vast, interconnected water bodies. Destroying or fragmenting them is not merely an environmental loss but is equivalent to dismantling part of the country's flood control infrastructure. Roads built across these haors can divide a connected wetland system into artificially wetter and drier sections. Farmers and environmentalists have warned how haor roads and the development that follows could invite disasters. The repeated flooding in the aftermath of these developments reinforced such concerns.

That Bangladesh needs roads and reliable transportation for haor communities is beyond question. But such infrastructure must be designed around the pathway of the water rather than imposed across it. Roads should include adequately sized and properly located bridges, culverts, causeways, and overflow sections that preserve natural water movement. Selective elevated sections could also work without turning the entire roadway into a barrier. However, once natural drainage and water storage areas are lost, engineered solutions become increasingly costly and less effective.



Shoppers and traders wade through standing water inside and outside New Market after heavy rain flooded the area, in Dhaka, Bangladesh on August 6, 2026. PHOTO: **PRABIR DAS**

Using AI and satellite data for precision forecasting

While Bangladesh has made significant progress in flood and cyclone preparedness, the current operational capacity focuses mainly on forecasting river levels at selected locations. The hydrological information system is underdeveloped too: when localised cloudbursts and extreme rainfall coincide with transboundary runoff, they generate catastrophic inundation within hours. Conventional forecasting, constrained by delayed data, limited upstream monitoring, and slow computer processing, cannot capture such sudden, highly localised anomalies in advance. At the community level, effective disaster risk reduction requires more precise information, such as which villages will be inundated, which roads will become impassable, how deep the water will be, when a flash flood will reach a particular haor, and how long the flooding will last. A next-generation flood mapping system must move beyond predicting river water level to answer these questions.

This is where AI can help by deriving "smart" location-specific flood forecasts. AI models can learn from rainfall, river levels, land elevations, land use, previous floods, and infrastructure conditions. They can identify flood patterns that are difficult to capture using a limited number of river gauges, particularly in ungauged and sparsely monitored areas. However, Bangladesh cannot simply import a model trained somewhere else. The system must be built and tested using Bangladeshi data, aided by advanced scientific expertise and community knowledge.

Similarly, the latest satellites offer capabilities that were unimaginable even a decade ago. Nasa's Global Precipitation Measurement Mission provides near real-time rainfall estimates over Bangladesh and upstream transboundary basins. European Sentinel-1 satellites use radar to observe the Earth through clouds, rain and darkness, making them especially valuable during monsoon floods. The Nasa-French Surface Water and Ocean Topography (SWOT) mission can measure changes in the width and elevation of rivers, lakes and wetlands. When combined with river gauges, weather forecasts, and community observations, these satellites could power an AI-enabled system that updates continuously. The result could be dynamic maps showing expected flood arrival time, water depth, duration, road accessibility, and potential impacts on crops and homes. Warnings could be delivered through mobile phones, local government offices, schools, community volunteers, and agricultural extension networks.

This technology should not be reserved for emergencies. AI and satellite data can also reveal where development is creating future disasters. Satellite observations can identify where a haor has been fragmented, a canal has narrowed, or construction has expanded into a flood storage area. AI can test thousands of rainfall and infrastructure scenarios to identify where flow restrictions could cause dangerous waterlogging. Before approving a road, housing development or industrial project in a floodplain, the authorities should be required to answer one basic question: where will the displaced water go?

Bangladesh also needs an integrated national water data platform where government agencies, universities and local organisations can work from consistent, regularly updated information. Even the most advanced warning system will fail if rainfall, river, wetland, infrastructure and land use data remain scattered across agencies or inaccessible. Publicly funded environmental data should be documented, interoperable and accessible to those responsible for protecting communities, agriculture and infrastructure.

However, no technology can replace a filled haor, reopen a blocked canal, or restore a floodplain buried beneath concrete. A smart flood mapping system may tell a community that it will flood tomorrow, while protecting wetlands and restoring drainage can reduce that risk for decades. The country must stop treating haor conservation, floodplain protection, infrastructure planning, and flood forecasting as separate issues. They are dimensions of the same national water security challenge, and they must be governed together. The real question is whether the institutions that approve our roads, bridges, and embankments understand this connection. Adopting a unified strategy pairing precision forecasting with ecological restoration is essential to make Bangladesh flood-resilient.

Tree planting alone won't make our cities greener



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NUSHRAT RAHMAN CHOWDHURY

Prime Minister Tarique Rahman launched the 25-crore tree plantation programme by planting a garjan sapling in Cox's Bazar in June this year. While trees are vital for people and nature, there are valid reasons to be deeply sceptical about such programmes. Tree planting programmes, for which the premier campaigns, are not new in Bangladesh. Between 2009 and 2024, former prime minister Sheikh Hasina inaugurated multiple environmental campaigns and tree-planting programmes, including a 30-lakh sapling planting programme to pay tribute to the Liberation War martyrs in 2018, a one-crore sapling planting programme to mark Mujib Borsho in 2019, and a 7.27-crore sapling planting programme in 2021.

The current administration's project closely mirrors past initiatives. It targets the same future generations, plants the same native varieties, and utilises the same ministries to combat climate change. But given this repetition, one has to ask: did the outcomes of those past programmes warrant doing the same thing again?

The EIU 2026 liveability index has ranked Dhaka the third least liveable city in the world. Home to around 3.5 crore people, the country's capital city has stubbornly remained at the bottom tier of this index for years, being consistently pulled down by environmental concerns, i.e. air pollution, loss of green and blue spaces, and high levels of environmental degradation. Almost two decades of tree plantation programmes have not been able to save Dhaka from hitting rock bottom.

Tree cover reduces exposure to excessive outdoor temperature and cools the environment by blocking incoming solar radiation, preventing concrete and asphalt from absorbing it. Other roles include cleaning air, reducing stormwater runoff, and providing shelter for birds and other forms of life necessary for ecological balance. At least 30 percent tree canopy cover is recommended to benefit cities.

Dhaka has lost half of its tree cover, dropping from 21.6 percent since 1980 to just 11.6 percent in 2024. Other cities share a similar fate: Chattogram has around 37 percent tree coverage, a 47 percent decline in three decades; and Rajshahi's green cover plummeted by 26 percent between 1990 and 2023. With over five crore people now living in the country's urban centres, we must urgently figure out why past tree planting programmes in the cities have failed, and take immediate corrective action. Major cities like Dhaka, Chattogram, Sylhet and Khulna are expanding rapidly, turning into "concrete jungles" and driving up local temperatures.

The government's actions on the environment often seem contradictory. The Malnichhara tree-felling in Sylhet, CRB's felling of century-old tree in Chattogram, and tree felling in Dhaka, including in Panthokunja Park, are examples where the city authorities have been accused of chopping off trees for beautification and development purposes. In Mohammadpur, where I live, we used to enjoy the canopy of trees and plants. In my neighbourhood, a mango tree sheltered birds and gave shade to rickshaw pullers, street vendors and passers-by. Authorities cut down thousands of trees for repeated utility works, yet waterlogging and service disruptions persist. With few replacement saplings surviving, green cover remains a fraction of what it once was.

The idea of cutting down trees for projects and planting more trees in their place is not realistic. A tree usually takes 10 to 20 years to mature. The replaced trees, if any, would take at least a decade to be of any use to people. Chopping trees triggers a chain reaction in the ecosystem, including loss of animal habitats and food sources. I often question the policies that allow the destruction of mature trees and their complex ecosystems, only to offer a few saplings as compensation. Isn't this simply greenwashing disguised as environmental progress?

Another aspect of such environmental plans that strike me as peculiar is that they are often focused on areas like Gulshan, Banani, Baridhara and Dhanmondi, which already have better environmental indicators such as vast tree canopy, lakes, and more parks than most other areas, while densely populated areas like Mohammadpur and Old Dhaka remain neglected and continue to suffer from worsening pollution. Such disproportionate actions exhibit how environmental inequality remains unaddressed.

Our cities cannot wait anymore. The government must take steps to make them liveable, combining multiple approaches, including keeping the existing trees and their ecosystems intact while planting new trees on a regular basis. Urban policies must be designed and implemented to effectively balance a city's practical needs with genuine environmental conservation.

The prime minister has been inspiring people to plant trees since the inauguration of the 25-crore tree plantation programme. It shows the leadership's commitment to improving environmental quality and combating climate change. However, these efforts may be in vain if the existing challenges are not confronted promptly.

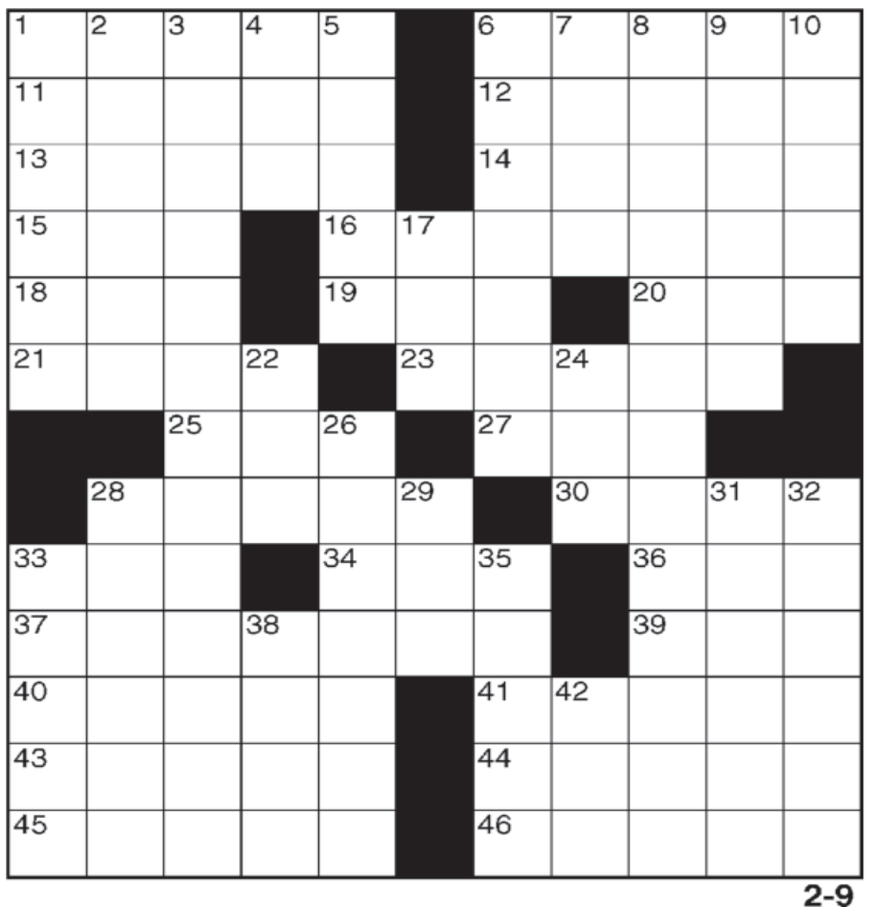
CROSSWORD
BY THOMAS JOSEPH

ACROSS

1 Show fear
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29 Nutrition label abbr.
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32 Designated
33 Banquet
35 Sleep sound
38 Stumble
42 Pod unit



2-9

THURSDAY'S ANSWERS

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Timeless Aisha, RELENTLESS AISHA

What matters to me is that Bangladeshi cinema reaches global audiences. However, I believe filmmakers representing Bangladesh internationally deserve greater institutional support. If the government could provide financial assistance to films selected for major festivals, it would encourage more filmmakers to take Bangladeshi stories to the world.



SHARMIN JOYA

After making a mark in OTT with memorable performances in projects such as ***Kaiser*** and ***Daag***, actress and host Aisha Khan has carved out a distinct place in the industry. Following her big-screen debut in ***Ahoto Phooler Golpo*** (2018), she returned to cinemas with Proshoon Rahmaan's ***Shekor***, starring opposite F S Nayeem. Released on July 31 to a warm reception, the film explores themes of identity, belonging, and the importance of preserving one's cultural roots across generations.

Aisha dropped by The Daily Star for an exclusive photoshoot, and shared her experience of working in the project, her solo tour and more.

How did 'Shekor' happen?

Proshoon *bhaia* was looking for a fresh face to play Phalguni, who is a singer and a teacher as well. His requirements were quite specific, and after Nayeem *bhaia* suggested my name, we met. What impressed me most was his narration. Before I even finished reading the script, I told him I wanted to do the film because I had already connected with the story.

What surprised me even more was his preparation. Three months before shooting, he presented an entire roadmap—from production to festival plans—in a presentation slide. Almost everything happened exactly as planned. I will always appreciate his professionalism.

Tell us about Phalguni. How similar are you to the character?

Phalguni is a classical singer who teaches and preserves our musical heritage. The biggest difference is that I cannot sing, while she is an accomplished vocalist. She is also very passionate about introducing Bangladesh's culture to people from outside the country.

Where we are similar is our love for our roots. Like Phalguni, I believe people who have moved away from their homeland should stay connected to their roots, even if returning permanently is not possible.

How was your experience of sharing the screens with F S Nayeem?

He is one of the most positive people I have met. Even if you ask him something negative, he somehow turns it into something positive. I try to learn that from him.

On set, despite being such a senior actor, he remained friendly and grounded. He was always punctual, cheerful and constantly making everyone laugh. Even before emotionally demanding scenes, he would keep the atmosphere light. Once the director called for action, he would instantly transform into the character. As a person he is wonderful, but as an artiste he is even better.

You have become quite selective about OTT and film projects. Why?

Either the scripts I receive don't appeal to me, or the remuneration doesn't work for the producers. The projects that brought me recognition had relatively small but memorable roles. For example, ***Kaiser***, ***Daag*** and ***Shekor***—will always remain the projects that I will always count to be the best of my career so far. That's exactly what I want now—characters that leave an impact, regardless of screen time.

Your film has travelled to festivals. What are your thoughts on festival recognition versus audience response?

Not every acclaimed film connects with every audience, and that's completely normal. A film can receive international recognition without becoming a commercial success at home.

What matters to me is that Bangladeshi cinema reaches global audiences. However, I believe filmmakers representing Bangladesh internationally deserve greater institutional support. If the government could provide financial assistance to films selected for major festivals, it would encourage more filmmakers to take Bangladeshi stories to the world.

You often travel to unwind. This time you went to Thailand, on a solo trip. How was the experience?

This was my fourth trip to Thailand, but it was the first time I truly explored Phuket. The first seven days were wonderful, but the last part of the trip turned into a stressful experience. While returning to Bangladesh, I missed my flight because of a payment issue at the airport. My cards suddenly stopped working, I was travelling alone, and I started to panic.

I later found out there was a spending limit on my card that I wasn't aware of. At that moment, I thought I might not be able to return home. Thankfully, one of my acquintances, the travel agency and a Bangladeshi couple I had never met before stepped in to help by making the payment on my behalf, and I transferred the money to them immediately. Their kindness is something I'll never forget.

The experience taught me an important lesson: never rely entirely on cards while travelling alone (laughs)—always carry enough cash as a backup.

Despite that difficult day, solo travel has helped me discover my own strengths. When you're on your own, you realise what you're capable of handling, and that confidence stays with you long after the trip ends.



PHOTOS: SHEIKH MEHEDI MORSHED

TRENDY STREAMS

Netflix
Best Medicine

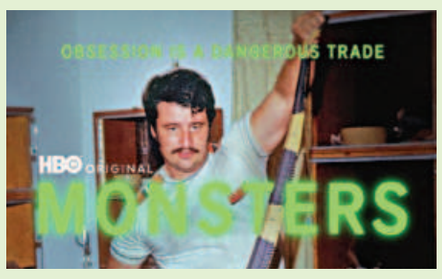


Hulu
Adults



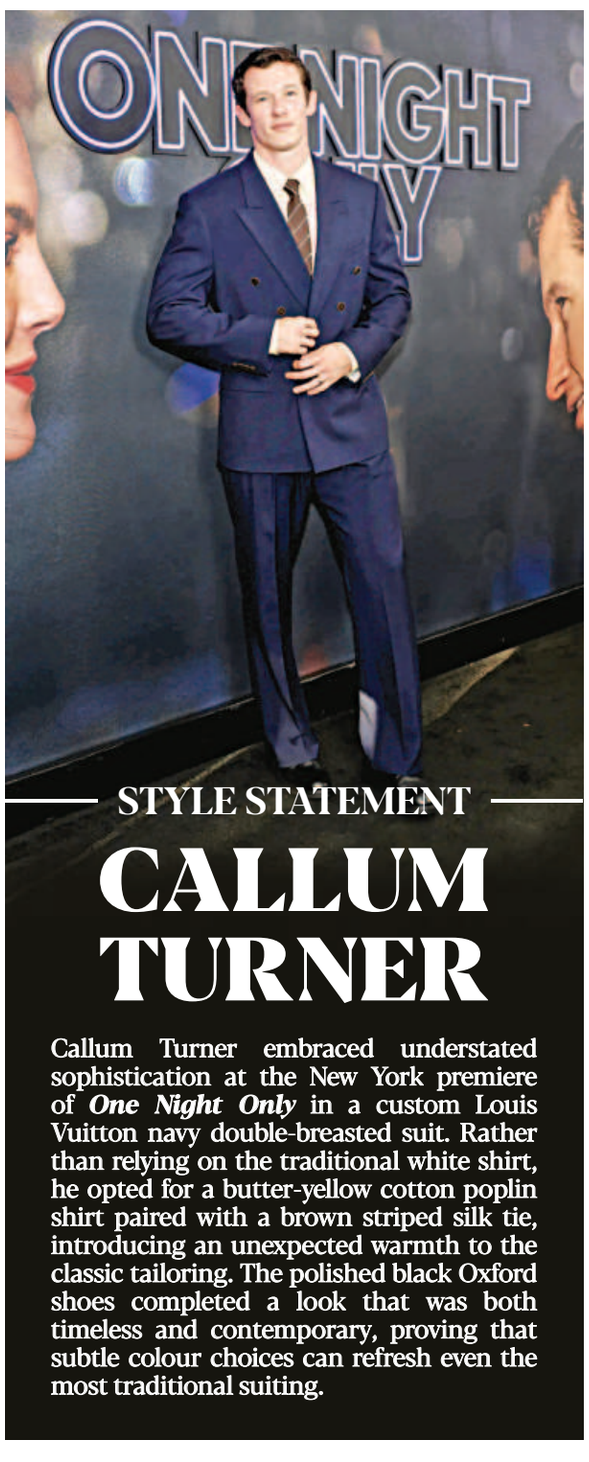
Prime Video
Sterling Point

HBO Max
Monsters Of God



Chorki
Paint on Dry Leaf





STYLE STATEMENT

CALLUM TURNER

Callum Turner embraced understated sophistication at the New York premiere of ***One Night Only*** in a custom Louis Vuitton navy double-breasted suit. Rather than relying on the traditional white shirt, he opted for a butter-yellow cotton poplin shirt paired with a brown striped silk tie, introducing an unexpected warmth to the classic tailoring. The polished black Oxford shoes completed a look that was both timeless and contemporary, proving that subtle colour choices can refresh even the most traditional suiting.

WHAT'S PLAYING

'Beauty and a Beat' by Justin Bieber feat. Nicki Minaj

Released in 2012, ***Beauty and a Beat*** was built for excess: thumping EDM production, a waterpark party and a Nicki Minaj verse that became almost as recognisable as its chorus. More than a decade later, the song is enjoying an unlikely second peak.

Bieber's recent return to the stage, coupled with a wave of social-media nostalgia, has brought the track back into heavy rotation. It has now surpassed two billion Spotify streams, while its deliberately chaotic, largely GoPro-shot video has attracted more than 1.2 billion YouTube views.

The song has not aged subtly, but subtlety was never its purpose. Loud, bright and knowingly overdone, ***Beauty and a Beat*** captures the maximalist pop of its period, and shows how quickly yesterday's excess can become today's comfort listening.



TV TALKIES



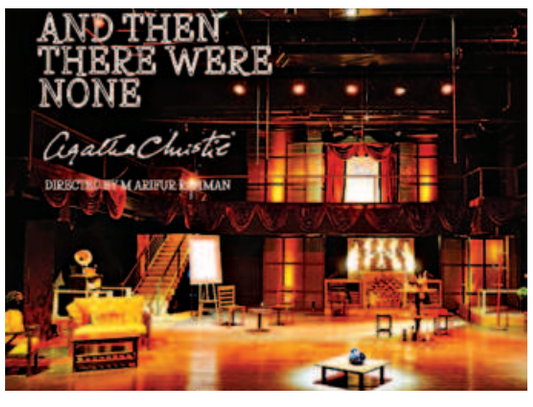
'Musafir Cafe'

Musafir Cafe is an eight-episode romantic drama series centred on a small cafe where strangers meet, friendships grow and lives change. The story follows Chander, Sudha and Preeti as they navigate love, heartbreak and unexpected turns. Adapted from Divya Prakash Dubey's bestselling novel, the series explores emotional connections, missed opportunities and second chances through a slow-burn narrative. Starring Vikrant Massey, Vedika Pinto and Mahima Makwana, ***Musafir Cafe*** is now streaming on Netflix.

OUT AND ABOUT IN DHAKA



'Silent Expressions'
August 1–10 | 4:00pm – 8:00pm
Batighar Art Space, Banani



'And Then There Were None'
August 15 | 4:00pm and 7:00pm
Experimental Theatre Hall, BSA



'Sojan Badiyar Ghat'
August 21–22 | 7:00pm
National Theatre Hall, BSA

Dhaka tops dengue cases, deaths

FROM PAGE 12

Metropolitan Women's College, I found Aedes mosquito larvae in a small container of water. Such breeding sites are common across the city, indicating that Aedes mosquitoes are reproducing continuously in residential areas."

Saifur said mosquito control efforts remain largely reactive rather than preventive.

"The most effective strategy would be to intensify mosquito control during periods when dengue transmission is relatively low. At that time, breeding sites are fewer, and interventions can be more effective. Instead, mosquito control usually intensifies only after the dengue season begins, by which time infections are already increasing rapidly."

Saifur said Bangladesh's failure to establish a centralised, proactive mosquito control programme has also contributed to the growing dengue burden.

Countries with centralised vector control systems generally achieve better outcomes than those relying on decentralised approaches, where mosquito control efforts vary from one city to another, he added.

Saifur called for establishing a national mosquito control authority staffed by expert entomologists to coordinate, oversee and monitor vector control activities across the country.

"Until we establish a coordinated national control system, dengue cases are likely to continue rising," he warned.

Prof Kabirul Bashar of zoology department at Jahangirnagar University warned that dengue infections are likely to continue increasing through August and may remain on an upward trend into September.

"The peak may not occur in August. It's possible that this year's peak will come in September. What we can say is that the upward trend is likely to continue through August and into September," he said.

The entomologist stressed that the government's priority should be source reduction and breeding-site management.

"The main strategy is eliminating mosquito breeding sites. Where breeding sites cannot be removed or destroyed, long-lasting insecticides or insect growth regulators should be applied," he added.

He also called for greater involvement by local government institutions, saying councillors and other local authorities should play a more active role in mosquito control and dengue prevention.



A man cools his child with water from the Fontana della Barcaccia during a heatwave in Rome, Italy, yesterday. A severe heatwave is putting growing pressure on power supplies, waterways and transport networks across Europe, with Italy placing every city in its national heat-health monitoring system under the highest alert. PHOTO: REUTERS

Motorboats, waste threaten ecosystem

FROM PAGE 12

On August 1, members of Charukala Barishal visited Bhimruli with students for an open-air painting session in the guava orchards.

Its secretary, Gourab Karmakar, said they had hoped to capture the area's tranquil beauty but found the atmosphere overwhelmed by engine noise.

"The constant noise shattered the silence. Even the birds flew away from the orchards," he said.

Tour operator Opu Nazrul, who recently brought a group of visitors to the area, said tourism development should not come at the expense of the environment.

"Tourism facilities should be developed without destroying the environment. Otherwise, the area will gradually lose its appeal," he told The Daily Star.

Nesarabad Upazila Nirbahi Officer Amit Dutta said the administration is aware of the growing concerns.

"About two weeks ago, I met boat operators and instructed them to stop using loud sound systems and reduce speed. We also put up notices across the area. We have already fined one operator and will intensify mobile court drives," he told The Daily Star.

Jhalakathi sadar upazila UNO Segufta Mehnaz said the tourist zone spans three upazilas in three districts, making enforcement challenging.

"I have already fined three boat operators. We have also issued public awareness notices through Facebook to encourage environmentally responsible tourism," she said.

According to the Department of Agricultural Extension, guava is cultivated on around 24,000 acres across Barishal, Jhalakathi and Pirojpur, producing more than 200,000 tonnes annually.

Almost all the guavas are sold at floating markets on the canals, drawing thousands of tourists from home and abroad every year.

But environmentalists warn that unplanned tourism is contributing to environmental degradation and threatening aquatic life, birds and biodiversity around the canals and orchards.

Rafiqul Alam, divisional coordinator of Bangladesh Poribesh Andolon, said the administrations of the three districts should jointly formulate a comprehensive tourism management plan.

"Without coordinated action, a major accident could occur at any time," he said.

Indian govt says it doesn't endorse

FROM PAGE 1

5, 2024, amid a mass uprising and has been sheltered by the Indian government since then, reiterated her plan to return to Bangladesh in December this year.

She was convicted by the International Crimes Tribunal for crimes against humanity committed during the uprising.

Bangladesh government sent letters to the Indian government seeking her extradition, but no response has yet been received.

As the event was publicised earlier by the Foreign Correspondents' Club of South Asia, Prime Minister's Foreign Affairs Adviser Humaiun Kobir sought New Delhi's cooperation in ensuring that no one, including Hasina, can use Indian territory to make political statements or conduct any activities aimed at creating instability in Bangladesh.

During a courtesy call on him by Indian High Commissioner Dinesh Trivedi on August 3, Kobir mentioned that such activities could harm the positive progress of bilateral relations between the two countries.

In response, Trivedi assured that the matter would be duly considered, necessary inquiries would be made, and efforts would be made in this regard.

However, the next day, Jaiswal at a media briefing said India had no involvement in the event that was organised by a private media entity.

After the media event in New Delhi, Bangladesh's foreign ministry issued a strong statement, saying, "On a day when the people of Bangladesh are observing the second anniversary of the July Revolution, this interaction by Sheikh Hasina on Indian soil stands as an affront to the sovereignty of Bangladesh and a grievous insult to the martyrs of the July Revolution."

The statement added that allowing her the opportunity to openly interact with the media under any pretext is deeply hurtful to Bangladeshi people's sentiment and detrimental to the development of harmonious bilateral relations between the two states.

BNP and National Citizen Party leaders also strongly criticised the Indian government, saying it was using Hasina as a tool to destabilise Bangladesh.

Bangladesh-India relations have remained strained since the ouster of Awami League government, though there have been signs of improvement following the formation of BNP government in February.

No way for Shakib to return now

FROM PAGE 12

led uprising that toppled Hasina's government.

The following day, Shakib told Reuters that he was ready to return to Bangladesh from his two-year exile, face trial on charges including murder and play a farewell series if the government guarantees his safety.

"If I get the clearance from the government that my security will be ensured, I am happy to go back, face the court trial and everything that's needed to be done," Shakib told Reuters by phone from Sri Lanka, where he is playing franchise cricket.

"I know I haven't done anything," he said.

Shakib has been living in the United States since Hasina's government was toppled in August 2024. He has not yet retired from international cricket and said he still hopes to play a farewell series at home and represent Bangladesh at the 2027 one-day World Cup.

He announced his retirement plans in September 2024 after Bangladesh's second Test against India but later said he would play a full series before calling it quits.

The Bangladesh Cricket Board said in January that he could play again, but his appearance at the Delhi event sparked anger in Bangladesh. His appearance came shortly before his ancestral home in Magura was attacked. Police said the property was unoccupied and no one was injured.

Shakib defended his virtual appearance, saying he had called only for peace and Bangladesh's progress and had no regrets.

Hasina has told Reuters that she and other Awami League leaders plan to return to Bangladesh voluntarily in December. Shakib said he wanted to return immediately but, failing that, would try to return alongside her.

He said he had written, through a lawyer, to the home, law and sports ministries under the previous interim government as well as to the police, seeking to have what he described as fabricated charges against him dropped, but received no response.

He said he was keen to speak to Prime Minister Tarique Rahman about returning.

Despite the uncertainty over his return, Shakib said he did not want to wait too long to retire.

"I am playing most of the franchise leagues. I am feeling good, still enjoying the game, playing well also," he said. "But ... age is not on my side at this moment, so I cannot wait for too long."

Shakib said that in late 2024, he boarded a flight home after receiving assurances from the interim government that he would be given security.

He said he called officials from the airport lounge to confirm that he was travelling, but was told midway through the journey to turn back. He landed in Dubai and returned to New York, where he lives on Long Island with his wife and three children.

He said a later attempt to return also collapsed after he posted a birthday message for Hasina on social media, which authorities cited as the reason for barring his re-entry.

Shakib also rejected suggestions from previous officials that distancing himself from Hasina and the Awami League could ease his return.

"There is no way I will consider that," he said.

Shakib said two cases against him are currently active: one over the alleged killing of a protester during the uprising and another brought by anti-corruption authorities over alleged corruption.

He said the murder case was filed on a day in August 2024 when he was playing a match in Toronto.

He also said his bank accounts had been frozen for a year and a half pending investigation.

Shakib said he had not seen his parents for two years. They have remained in Bangladesh and, he said, have not been allowed to leave.

Thai teen kills 7 in rampage at home

FROM PAGE 12

children and tearful students and staff comforted each other outside.

"I was afraid that I would die, and I was scared that I wouldn't be able to pursue my dreams," said Pawarisa Maylissa, a grade 12 student who hopes to attend medical school.

"I heard many gunshots very loudly because it seemed the suspect was on the floor directly above us," she told AFP.

Prime Minister Anutin Charnvirakul told reporters at the scene that "police interrogated his close friend who said the suspect had been under stress" related to his schooling.

"His actions also suggested that he had clearly planned" the assault, Anutin added. "The gun was a registered firearm and was kept at a house, but somehow he gained access to it."

The prime minister said more than 30 people were injured, with around nine in critical condition. The shooter was identified by local media as a student of the school.

Anutin vowed to introduce a new firearms control law in Southeast Asia's largest gun-owning nation.

Purin Khumchoo, 17, said he was among the students who had nearly been shot. "He was my junior, but I had a feeling that he was a troubled kid. My group of friends who knew him said he was interested in the FBI and guns, and that he was bullied by many other students," Purin told AFP outside his school.

"When I saw him aiming the gun at me, I thought he looked very professional, as if he had been trained for a long time."

Photos published by local media show the suspect wearing a purple school uniform and carrying a black cross-body bag, with several bullet casings visible on the ground.

Education Minister Prasert Jantararuangtong pledged to provide mental health assistance to students and ramp up security measures at educational institutions.

"We haven't checked whether students have brought weapons to school. Our level of security is not that tight," he told reporters at the school.

Thongchai Thanakat, a motorcycle-taxi driver who has worked in the area for 20 years, said he was waiting to pick up passengers outside the school when he heard more than 10 gunshots and saw a stream of students rushing out.

"Some of them weren't even wearing shoes," he told AFP.

Thailand has one of the highest rates of gun ownership in the region, with around 10 million firearms estimated to be in circulation -- one for every seven inhabitants.

Past promises of tightening gun laws have not prevented repeated shootings.

Thai police shot and arrested a teenager who opened fire at a school in the south of the country in February, killing the principal and wounding two students.

The teen had stabbed a police officer with a knife, stole his pistol and then used the weapon in the shooting.

A local police chief said at the time that the suspect had been discharged from psychiatric hospitalisation.

In 2022, an ex-policeman armed with a gun and a knife stormed into a nursery in the country's north, killing 24 children and 12 adults in one of Thailand's deadliest massacres.

Football world splits over Infantino

FROM PAGE 12

the opposition to Infantino, which initially appeared overwhelming following the collapse of FFE, is no longer as straightforward as it seemed.

The proposal, which FIFA said could raise around $4.2 billion by selling a roughly 20-percent minority stake in a new commercial subsidiary valued at $20 billion, initially united much of football against Infantino.

UEFA and its 55 member associations threatened to boycott FIFA competitions and, on Thursday, doubled down on its earlier statement saying it no longer had "confidence" in Infantino. UEFA's threat to boycott the World Cup is believed to have been pivotal in forcing Infantino to shelve the investment plan.

CONCACAF's 41 members also rejected the proposal, while the AFC stood in solidarity with the opposition.

The backlash was so severe that Infantino abandoned the plan within days, despite having previously vowed to pursue an "open and democratic" consultation with stakeholders. FIFA subsequently apologised to its members and promised to review the processes that had led to the controversy.

At that point, Infantino appeared increasingly isolated.

But the picture has since changed.

The Confederation of African Football (CAF) gave Infantino unanimous backing on Thursday, while Argentina and Mexico have publicly sided with him. Paraguay has also reaffirmed its commitment to working alongside FIFA.

Mexico's position is particularly noteworthy. One of the three co-hosts of the recently concluded World Cup -- the biggest edition in history, featuring a record 48 nations -- the FMF broke ranks with CONCACAF by supporting Infantino.

"The FMF will neither recognise nor approve any process convened outside of that institutional framework," it said, while backing Infantino's call to continue developing football "for the benefit of the 211 member associations".

"The FMF supports President Infantino's leadership in continuing to promote the development of football through institutional strengthening," it added.

South America has adopted a similarly nuanced position. CONMEBOL expressed concern over "repeated unilateral actions taken without resorting to dialogue" but also rejected any attempt to remove Infantino without a vote involving all 211 FIFA members.

That position is in line with the AFA's decision to acknowledge the failures surrounding FFE while still backing FIFA's leadership.

Against that backdrop, Norway's latest move has further exposed the divide.

"He does not have the institutional trust required to lead FIFA in a stable manner in the current climate. There is no turning back for Gianni Infantino," Klaveness, NFF president and one of Infantino's longest-standing critics, said.

"Given the chaos we find ourselves in, he can no longer be the figure capable of uniting people."

Norway has also decided to refer three matters to FIFA's ethics committee -- the aborted private-investment plan, the lifting of Folarin Balogun's suspension at the 2026 World Cup following an intervention by US President Donald Trump, and FIFA's decision to award Trump a so-called 'Peace Prize'. The federation will also seek a full review of the reforms promised by Infantino.

Klaveness's call comes as Infantino prepares to seek a fourth and final term at FIFA's presidential election in Rabat on March 19, 2027. He remains the only declared candidate, with nominations closing on November 18.

There is also a mechanism for an extraordinary FIFA Congress to be called, where a vote of no confidence in Infantino could be held.

Klaveness has herself been suggested as a potential successor, with former FIFA president Sepp Blatter even backing the idea of her becoming the first woman to lead world football. But she distanced herself from the speculation.

"We're not there yet," she told AFP. "For us, it's now about the issues I just mentioned, and not about particular individuals."

Infantino had looked virtually certain to secure a fourth and final term after being elected in 2016 and re-elected unopposed in 2019 and 2023. But FFE has complicated that picture, potentially weakening his standing among UEFA, CONCACAF and parts of the AFC while prompting others to publicly reaffirm their loyalty.

KSA, Turkey, Pakistan

FROM PAGE 12

regarded as an attack on all, they said in a joint statement.

A Saudi official said the joint defence pact was not linked to "any nuclear ambitions" and was not a threat to any country in the region.

The three nations are particularly concerned by the increasingly aggressive military stances of both Israel and Iran, as their longtime US ally struggles to contain regional upheaval, reports Reuters.

US President Donald Trump on Thursday told reporters that he believed the war with Iran would be over soon and said the armed forces were experiencing issues with supplies of some weapons.

"I think it's going to end pretty soon. I don't think they can go much longer," Trump said in the Oval Office in a reference to Iran.

When asked about the status of munitions stockpiles, Trump said the country had an almost unlimited supply of certain weapons but acknowledged inventories of others were limited.

He has ordered new investigations into the disclosures of the munitions stockpile, The Wall Street Journal reports, citing administration officials.

The US president's comments came as the Iranian parliament is reviewing the initial text of an agreement governing the Strait of Hormuz banning "vessels from hostile countries" from accessing the waterway, Al Jazeera reports citing state broadcaster IRIB.

The broadcaster adds that countries and individuals that "have caused damage to Iran" will not receive permission to pass until they pay for compensation. Oil prices extended gains and stocks fell further yesterday amid fading optimism over the deal to reopen the strait.

Four industry sources said that a proposed deal between Iran and Oman that would give Tehran control over ships entering the Gulf through the strait is not easily workable due to US sanctions and restrictive insurance clauses on any payments.

US Central Command (Centcom) said on Thursday evening that 49 commercial vessels have been redirected, two disabled and two boarded as part of a naval blockade of Iran.

Meanwhile, Houthi drone attacks on Yemen's Marib province killed five members of government forces yesterday, a Yemeni military source told AFP, as rebels ramped up the conflict a day after the deadliest Houthi attack in years.

Saudi Arabia expects imminent coordinated attacks from Iraqi militias north of the Gulf state and from Houthis from the south under the supervision of Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, a senior Saudi official said.

In a separate development, Israel has refused to withdraw from more areas of south Lebanon unless the Lebanese army has full control of an initial two "pilot zones", a Lebanese presidential source said.

Chhatra Dal leader falls to death during police raid

FROM PAGE 2

Police followed him, and at one point he fell from the five-storey building, the OC said.

A five-member committee has been formed to investigate the incident, he added.

Neighbour Russell Moni alleged that after hearing a loud noise around 12:30am, he saw Monowarul lying on the ground while a police member was on the rooftop. He claimed police left the scene shortly afterwards.

A doctor from the BPATC clinic was initially called to the scene. Following the doctor's advice, he was rushed to Shaheed Suhrawardy Medical College Hospital for treatment where duty doctor declared him dead on arrival, he added.

Mahfuz Iqbal, general secretary of the Dhaka North unit of Jatiyatabadi Chhatra Dal, alleged that police left the scene instead of taking Monowarul to hospital.

Md Selim Ali, officer-in-charge of Pirgachha Police Station, said the missing girl and the young man were not found during the raid, as they had reportedly left before police arrived.

"Only Jafar Ali and his wife were present at the flat. While we were speaking with them, we heard a loud noise from outside. We found a young man lying on the ground. Jafar Ali later identified him as his son, Monowarul," OC Selim said.

ESSAY

A humanist in the age of AI

NOORA SHAMSI BAHAR



ILLUSTRATION: MAHMUDA EMDAD

For centuries, literature asked us to believe that language is more than information, that it's a rich repository of history, memory, grief, longing, humour, silence, and entire ways of seeing and making sense of the world. Literary translation asks us to believe something even more difficult, that these things can survive the crossing into another language. I've spent years studying and teaching literature, translating Bengali works into English, and believing that every translation demands not merely linguistic prowess, but intercultural sensitivity, an intimacy with two worlds, ethical responsibility, and of course, creative intuition and translatorial intervention.

Yet I find myself working in a capitalist landscape where the arts and humanities must justify their existence and where creative labour is evaluated based on whether it can be done more cheaply, more quickly, or more efficiently by AI. Not for a moment do I believe artificial intelligence can replicate the human experience that gives birth to literature or the profoundly human act of literary translation. What I fear instead is that many institutions, publishers, producers, and clients no longer care enough about the distinction between human creativity and machine-generated output. The overall winner of the 2026 Commonwealth Short Story Prize was allegedly an AI-generated piece. Nobel Prize winner Olga Tokarczuk admitted using AI to develop ideas. A member of my cohort in the University of Iowa's MFA in Literary Translation program was commissioned to produce a short sample translation of a Finnish novel, only to see the completed English translation be generated by AI. Filmmakers no longer require professional subtitlers. Across industries, efficiency is rewarded while craftsmanship is treated as unnecessary extravagance.

Would AI arrive at these same negotiations and interventions? Perhaps. Perhaps not. I neither know, nor do I particularly care to find out. My translation is uniquely mine, shaped by my literary sensibilities, cultural experiences, theoretical commitments, and countless acts of hesitation and revision.

How many literary giants would have remained strangers to us without the invisible labour of translators? Would the world have embraced Gabriel Garcia Marquez as it did without Gregory Rabassa's extraordinary English translations? In a more local context, would Rabindranath Tagore have become the first non-European Nobel laureate in Literature had he not translated *Gitanjali* into English himself? Translation has always ensured literature's afterlife; it has always been one of the conditions of literature's survival across time and borders — both geographical and linguistic. This should allow readers to remember not only the author whose name appears on the cover, but also the translator who made that literary encounter possible.

As an emerging literary translator, the countless hours spent wrestling with a single sentence or a single word, the labour of listening to the soundscape of two languages, the perseverance required to negotiate syntax, cadence, cultural nuance, and even silence, and the conviction that every translation is an act of cultural stewardship rather than mere linguistic substitution—all of it begins to feel invisible in an economy that prizes production over artistry.

Let me provide examples of the kind of processes a literary translator must go through and let the reader ponder over whether AI would be able to do the same.

In Jibanananda Das's poem "Beral", the first couple of lines read:

"Sharadin ekta beraler shongge ghure
phire keboli amar dekha hoy:
Gachher chhayay, rod er bhitore, badami patar bhire;"

I translated "badami" multiple times before settling on "peanuty". Badami is the colour of the reddish-brown flaky skin covering the peanut kernel. In the context of Bangladesh, peanuts are never had raw or boiled; they are roasted, turning the kernel's skin to a rich reddish-brown. "Auburn" matches the shade but evokes a contemporary hair colour; "burnt umber" or "burnt sienna" feels long and painterly; "chestnut" implies the wrong tree. None capture the playfulness of "badami." I chose the literal "peanuty," which preserves both colour and interpretive openness.

The same poem's final image is quite striking:

"Tarpor ondhokarke chhoto chhoto
ball er moto thaba diye lufe anlo shey
Shomosto prithibir bhitor chhoriye dilo."

In my translation:

then, she scoops up little balls of darkness
and scatters them across the breadth of the world.

Das uses a simile in the penultimate line. A meaningful, grammatically correct structure would be: "then, with her paws, she catches darkness as if they were little balls." However, I felt that this would read better if turned into a metaphor: "then, she scoops up little balls of darkness" (Note: I avoided the repetition of "with her paws" as it was already used in the previous line). I made the last line more dramatic, so instead of something like "and spread them across the world", I translated it as: "and scatters them across the breadth of the world." The verb "scatters" seems more fitting, compared to "spread". The accurate "spread" implies a smooth, even distribution and that kind of perfection sounds more divine, as if the hand of God is involved. However, with a cat as the subject, a more random, dispersed distribution makes more sense.

Because Bengali lacks gendered pronouns, the cat's sex remains unknown. Assigning femininity was my own interpretive choice. I avoided "it," which felt objectifying and ill-suited for a creature who is portrayed not as a pet but as a possibly spectral, self-willed being who plays cosmologically with light and darkness, and appears and disappears with uncanny ease.

I could provide a dozen other examples of the mental processes involved in translating the entire poem, but I hope the aforementioned three will suffice. Would AI arrive at these same negotiations and interventions? Perhaps. Perhaps not. I neither know, nor do I particularly care to find out. My translation is uniquely mine, shaped by my literary sensibilities, cultural experiences, theoretical commitments, and countless acts of hesitation and revision. I have no desire to measure it against ChatGPT's output. Perhaps my stubbornness is borne of heartbreak—a grief carried by humanists whose creative labour is undervalued in the age of AI.

Still, I write. Still, I translate. To borrow from Maya Angelou, "Still, I rise".

Noora Shamsi Bahar *is a writer, translator, and MFA candidate in Literary Translation at the University of Iowa.*

FICTION

Sapiosexual

MAHBUB MORSHED



ILLUSTRATION: MAHMUDA EMDAD

A single night's rain submerged Dhaka city, and my mind kept drifting back to my friend Kaisar. Though to be fair, he couldn't really be called a friend in the truest sense anymore. Nowadays, we only catch up occasionally, at long intervals. After a brief exchange of superficial updates, we lapsed back into months of silence.

Yet there was a time when Kaisar and I were in touch every single day. We used to explore art and culture together. We were likely around the same age, give or take a year or two. Curiously, I always addressed him with the formal "apni", using his first name, and Kaisar did the same with me. Whenever there was a painting exhibition, an installation, or a classical music concert, the two of us would go together. We were staples at art-film screenings as well. Almost every evening, we would hang out and chat at the Aziz Super Market. It was a good life. But somehow, imperceptibly, we drifted apart. It took me years to realize that my regular contact with Kaisar had completely ceased. The estrangement seemed to stem from both sides, without any specific incident to blame.

Kaisar began occupying my thoughts from the moment the rainy morning broke. Gradually, so many memories of those old days flooded back that my mind became submerged knee-deep in nostalgia, just as Dhaka city was drowning waist-deep in water.

The rain had started in the early hours before dawn on the first of July, and it showed no sign of stopping. Even while half-asleep, I could tell a torrential downpour had begun outside. The wind howled, rattling against the windowpanes. Yielding to the cozy temptation, I rolled over without leaving the bed, and the cool draft lulled me into a second, deeper slumber.

When I finally got up at nine, I saw that all the surrounding alleys were swallowed by waist-deep water. My Facebook feed was flooded with pictures of waterlogging. People were posting snapshots of a submerged Dhaka from every corner. Students were stranded, unable to reach schools, colleges, or universities. Office-goers stood bewildered on overflowing pavements. Buses, CNGs, and rickshaws looked as though they were on the verge of sinking entirely. The streets in areas like Mirpur, Dhanmondi, and Mohammadpur resembled rushing rivers. People were making memes, photoshopping boats, steamers, and submarines onto flooded streets to troll the situation. Some lamented that plastic would eventually destroy the world.

According to a segment of Dhaka's residents, discarded chips packets scattered everywhere were the root cause of the waterlogging. Another group argued that it wasn't chips, packets, plastic, or polythene, but rather the systematic filling up of rivers, canals, marshes, and water bodies to construct high-rises that caused the crisis. The government drafts countless plans, claiming every year that waterlogging will be a thing of the past by the following year. Yet, the moment heavy rains lash the city next monsoon, the whole town goes under again. Then, government officials and their loyalists deflect, claiming that since citizens refuse to stop littering chips packets everywhere, the waterlogging will persist. They blame plastic and polythene. Yet, the government does nothing to clear the plastic, nor do they take steps to curb its usage. Meanwhile, the opposition and government supporters alike maintain their habit of tossing empty packets wherever they please after eating chips. Consequently, whenever it rains heavily, city dwellers brace themselves for the inevitable deluge. And once it floods, the entire city grinds to a halt for a day or two.

Many years ago, on a similarly rainy day, Kaisar and I had travelled to Dhanmondi, drenched to the bone.

It wasn't solely the rain that brought that day or Kaisar back to my mind. The true catalyst was Maymuna. Three days ago, Maymuna told me a strange story. Well, not a story, but she shared a real-life incident. Maymuna's tale revolved around a mysterious painting. As I listened to her, I realized that I already knew another piece of the same puzzle she was describing. If one were to piece them together, it would form an incredible narrative. Yet, I chose to remain a silent listener, keeping my side of the story to myself. I felt it wouldn't be right to tell Maymuna. But ever since hearing her account, a flood of old memories had been unlocked, and I felt a sudden, urgent need to see Kaisar as soon as possible.

I couldn't fathom why this bizarre metaphor kept recurring in my mind. But every time I stared at the dark, impending rain clouds, the image of thick white milk churning in the heavens flashed before me.

My mind kept wandering back to the events involving Akhtarul Islam twenty years ago, right at the dawn of my professional life. I muttered to myself, What a time that was!

*

Kaisar was supposed to arrive at my office at 5:00 PM. Sitting in my cubicle, I watched through the large glass window. Dense clouds had gathered. The colour of the clouds was a deep, heavy black, yet to me, they looked like thick, curdled white milk swirling across the sky. I couldn't fathom why this bizarre metaphor kept recurring in my mind. But every time I stared at the dark, impending rain clouds, the image of thick white milk churning in the heavens flashed before me. As time ticked away, the clouds grew heavier, more saturated, and damper. Perhaps, deep within, the friction of water particles was warming them up. Maybe the vast, churning water vapour had made the lower layers of the clouds restless.

Someone remarked, "It's going to pour today. A proper downpour."

Secretly, I hoped Kaisar wouldn't show up. I wished he'd get stuck somewhere or that some excuse would cancel the Dhanmondi trip. The rain was coming; there was no stopping it. As far as the eye could see, there was nothing but clouds. A massive formation of cosmic water vapour hung over the entirety of South Asia like a well-marshalled army. The moment war was declared, it would unleash itself upon the earth like a volley of buckshot.

Translated by Alamgir Mohammad. This is an excerpt. Read the rest of the story on *The Daily Star* and Star Books and Literature websites.

Alamgir Mohammad *teaches literature and Translation Studies at the tertiary level. He has published 25 titles in translation.*

Star SPORT
DHAKA SATURDAY AUGUST 8, 2026, SRABAN 24, 1433 BS

What to WATCH

T SPORTS
Bangladesh HP vs Malaysia
1st T20
Live from 2:00 pm
Lanka Premier League
Final
Live from 8:00 pm


PHOTO: CRICKET AUSTRALIA

Tigers' third-pacer conundrum

SPORTS REPORTER

Bangladesh pacers started the morning session on the second day of their three-day warm-up against Cricket Australia XI on the front foot, with Hasan Mahmud castling Josh Phillipe with just his second delivery of the day at the DXC Arena in Darwin yesterday.

However, by the end of the day, the Bangladesh team management must have been left wondering who would be their third seamer in the first Test in Darwin, starting on August 13, as CA XI posted 355.

With Shoriful Islam ruled out of the first Test and Nahid Rana set to miss the entire series due to injuries, the performance of Khaled Ahmed and Ebadot Hossain yesterday will hardly have made the decision easier.

Hasan found the best lengths for the surface early and reaped the rewards, finishing with a four-wicket haul. Taskin Ahmed at the other end also started promisingly, and the two premier quicks held their own for most of the day. In between, however, Khaled and Ebadot were left disappointed that they did not make more of their opportunities.

While Hasan was almost always on the money with his lengths, the others were not as consistent. Khaled and Ebadot were often guilty of failing to consistently hit a zone that tested the batters.

Khaled, though, started brightly, moving the ball away from left-handers and hitting the shoulder of the bat on several occasions while extracting steep bounce. Ebadot also tested the batters and got among the wickets, with left-hander Jack Clayton unable to control a pull shot and holing out at deep fine-leg.

Yet, while both bowlers produced edges, with a few flying past or through the slip cordon for boundaries, they also bowled boundary deliveries, erring in line as well. Their shorter lengths allowed the batters to get behind the ball and punish anything short on a wicket that was not typically Australian. As the wicket baked under the sun, the pace on the surface became more batting-friendly.

Bangladesh also had to deal with the injury Taijul Islam suffered while batting on the first day, which saw him rested from bowling in the CA XI first innings yesterday, with pacer Musfik Hasan taking his place. Despite the perseverance of Taskin and Hasan, pressure was released by the other three pacers, with Khaled going at an economy rate of 4.13, Ebadot 5.07 and Musfik 9.50.

Teague Wyllie (130) and Jake Doran (76) put together a 166-run sixth-wicket stand before lone spinner Mehidy Miraz removed the latter. Ebadot and Khaled managed one wicket each, and with Shoriful and Nahid unavailable for the first Test, it will come down to which of the two gets the nod.

However, their recent red-ball numbers will hardly make the decision easier. Since returning from an ACL injury, Ebadot has played four Tests, taking just one wicket at an average of 290 and an economy rate of 4.08. Khaled, meanwhile, has taken six wickets in his last four Tests at an average of 38.5 and an economy rate of 3.6.

Either will, however, have to replace Bangladesh's fastest quick Nahid, who bagged 11 wickets in two Tests this year alone. With at least three pacers expected to feature in the first of the two-Test series, the Tigers' team management face a difficult decision over who to trust with the third spot.

City reject Barca's opening offer for Rodri

AGENCIES

Manchester City have rejected Barcelona's opening offer of £38.5m for Spanish midfielder Rodri yesterday.

According to a BBC Sport report, City are open to selling the 30-year-old, but would consider the transfer for double or more than Barca's opening offer.

Spain's World Cup-winning captain has entered the final year of his contract at Etihad Stadium and is yet to sign a new deal, which remains on the table.



Real Madrid looked to be front-runners for Rodri's signature but LaLiga champions Barcelona are now believed to be his preference. According to the report, talks with Real have now ended.

Rodri missed much of the 2024-25 campaign after sustaining a serious knee injury, and parts of last season were disrupted by a hamstring issue. However, the 2024 Ballon d'Or winner was back to his best at the World Cup in the summer, leading Spain to their second title and being named player of the tournament. Rodri underwent surgery on a back complaint late last month that is expected to rule him out of the start of the new season.

City are on a pre-season tour of Asia and will face Atletico Madrid in Seoul on Sunday. They face Arsenal in the Community Shield the following Saturday and kick off their Premier League season at home to Bournemouth on August 23.

Emerging team reach tri-series final

SPORTS REPORTER

Bangladesh emerging team reached the final of the tri-series in South Africa after defeating University Sport South Africa (USSA) by seven wickets in their third match at Irene Country Club in Centurion yesterday.

Opting to field, pacer Chowdhury Rizwan starred with 4-28, while Rohanat Doullah Borson and Aminul Islam Biplob took two wickets each as Bangladesh bowled USSA out for 166 in 33.5 overs, picking their last nine wickets for just 40 runs.

Bangladesh also lost both openers early in the chase, but captain Shahadat Hossain Dipu's unbeaten 73 off 56 balls and Irfaan Shukkur's unbeaten 58 off 39 deliveries guided them to the target in 21.5 overs.

Bangladesh earlier beat USSA by 26 runs via the DLS method. They had started the tournament with a seven-wicket defeat to South Africa emerging team after being bowled out for 89.

Bangladesh will face South Africa emerging team in their final league-stage match at Tuks Oval in Pretoria on Sunday, effectively a dress rehearsal for the final, which will also be held at the same venue on August 12.

Kings, Abahani given another lifeline

SPORTS REPORTER

Six-time champions Abahani, five-time winners Bashundhara Kings and Fakirerpool Young Men's Club have been given four more days to resolve their FIFA registration bans after Bangladesh Football Federation (BFF) extended the club licensing submission deadline to August 11.

All three clubs need to lift their bans and secure licences to participate in the upcoming season, but none have managed to do so yet, leaving players waiting for contracts anxious.

"The officials of both clubs -- Bashundhara Kings and Abahani -- verbally requested us to extend the deadline of the club licensing, and we decided to extend it up to August 11 for the sake of the country's football interest because we want all clubs to participate in the Bangladesh Football League [beginning August 21]," BFF general secretary Emran Hossain told The Daily Star yesterday.

With the transfer window also nearing its close, players from Kings and Abahani remain uncertain about their futures.

"We have been kept waiting as the club has been trying to lift the bans. We all players are in tension as the transfer window is also coming to a close," Topu Barman, who captained Kings last season, told The Daily Star.

"From our hearts, we want Bashundhara Kings to get eligible to take part in the professional football league," Topu said. "The footballers from all clubs have been suffering for the last two seasons with less payment and if Kings fail to participate in the league, then it will be a big blow for the families of 30 to 35 footballers who are supposed to play for Kings."

He added that Kings' absence would also hurt the country's football, as players would lose access to the club's facilities.

The 31-year-old defender, however, remains hopeful after club president Imrul Hasan assured players at a meeting on Thursday that the issues would be resolved soon.

Meanwhile, midfielder Sheikh Morsalin, who featured in Abahani colours last season, is also waiting for clarity over his future.

"We have just been told that the club is trying to lift the bans, but we haven't been told anything about our new contracts," said Morsalin, adding he could remain without a club for the season if he cannot secure a suitable deal.

While Abahani's board is arranging funds to clear the bans, the club management remains in the dark about the club's plan on squad formation.

FIFA imposed registration bans on four clubs last season, including now-defunct Sheikh Jamal Dhanmondi Club, over unpaid dues to foreign players and coaching staff. While Sheikh Jamal had disappeared from the scene, Kings, Abahani and Fakirerpool have been working to settle their outstanding cases.

Abahani are closest to a resolution, having already lifted two bans, with the final one expected to be withdrawn soon. A club official said a portion of dues had already been sent to a Syrian player, with the ban expected to be lifted within days.

Kings' situation remains unclear, as no club official has spoken publicly since FIFA imposed the latest ban on August 5.

'Like me, but better'

AFP, *London*

Brendon McCullum has backed Stephen Fleming to succeed as England's new Test coach, describing his former New Zealand teammate as "like me, but better".

Fleming, 53, will take over from McCullum for England's tour of South Africa later this year, with the ECB reverting to a split coaching set-up after McCullum was sacked as red-ball coach following a woeful Ashes campaign and a 2-1 home series defeat to New Zealand. McCullum, however, remains in charge of the limited-overs sides.



Fleming has never coached a national team but has won five Indian Premier League titles with Indian Premier League side Chennai Super Kings. As New Zealand captain, he won 28 of his 80 Tests -- the most -- and scored 7,172 runs in 111 appearances.

"To get someone like him to commit to English cricket is an outstanding achievement," McCullum told Sky Sports. "I had a great time for those four years and now it's heading in a different direction. Flem will be excellent. He's a little bit like me, but better."

"Flem and I talk pretty much every day, we're close mates and we've done a lot together. He's one of those guys I trust completely. We want to be able to set this thing up so England is successful across all three formats of the game," he said.



Vini stays at Real

Vinicius Junior continued training with Real Madrid yesterday ahead of Los Blancos' pre-season friendly against Ferencvarosi TC in Budapest today. Although the Brazilian forward joined the camp last week, his latest involvement comes with greater certainty over his future, with Real Madrid finally securing his services by extending his contract until June 2032 and ending months of speculation over his next move. Talks had reached an impasse before the club made an improved offer, which the 26-year-old accepted after entering the final year of his previous deal. Vinicius had been linked with a move to English champions Arsenal. The Spanish giants have also bolstered their squad with Yan Diomande, Bernardo Silva, Ibrahima Konate, Marc Cucurella and Denzel Dumfries ahead of the new season.

PHOTO: REAL MADRID







FLOATING GUAVA ORCHARDS

Motorboats, waste threaten ecosystem

SUSHANTA GHOSH, *Barishal*

The winding canals branching off the Sugandha river weave through the famed floating guava orchards of Jhalakathi and Pirojpur, creating one of southern Bangladesh's most distinctive agricultural landscapes.

But during the monsoon tourism season, the tranquility of these waterways is increasingly disrupted by the roar of motorboats, mounting plastic waste and oil contamination.

As thousands of tourists arrive to explore the orchards and narrow canals, environmentalists, locals and visitors warn that unplanned tourism is threatening the fragile ecosystem that draws people to the region in the first place.

According to local business owners, between 3,000 and 5,000 tourists visit the area daily during the peak season.

More than 100 small and large boats operate across Bhimruli, Ata, Adamkathi, Atghar and Kuriana canals during the season, said Bikash Halder, coordinator of the Bhimruli Local Trawler Operators Association.

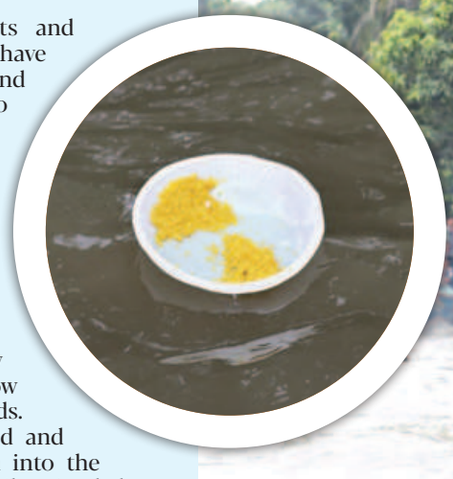
Around 50 restaurants and several recreational parks have also been established around the orchards to cater to visitors.

During a visit to Bhimruli in Jhalakathi and Atghar-Kuriana, Adamkathi, Ata and Jindakathi in Pirojpur's Nesarabad upazila in early August, The Daily Star observed high-speed boats repeatedly navigating the narrow canals through the orchards.

Plastic waste from food and drinks was being thrown into the waterways, while engine oil stained the canal water.

The constant movement of these engine-powered boats is also contributing to bank erosion, causing trees along the canal banks to be uprooted and fall into the water, locals and tourists said.

SEE PAGE 9 COL 1





Tourists ride motorboats through a narrow canal near the floating guava market in Bhimruli, Jhalakathi. The seasonal influx of visitors has brought heavy boat traffic to the narrow waterways. Locals say waves generated by the boats erode the canal banks, while discarded food and plastic waste pollute the water. The photo was taken recently. PHOTO: TITU DAS

MIDDLE EAST CONFLICTS

KSA, Turkey, Pakistan sign defence deal

Pact treats attack on one as attack on all



PHOTO: REUTERS

AGENCIES

Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Turkey yesterday signed a joint defence agreement in Makkah, wedding Sunni Muslim US allies alarmed at a regional conflagration that has rained missile fire onto Gulf oil exporters.

Iran and its allies have been firing on Saudi Arabia and other Gulf states, and blockading their energy shipments, since the US and Israel attacked it on February 28 in a major escalation after years of regional tumult.

The agreement is intended to strengthen collective deterrence against any act of aggression and stipulates that an armed attack against any of the three would be

SEE PAGE 9 COL 4

Dhaka tops dengue cases, deaths

Experts call for centralised mosquito control system

HELEMUL ALAM

Dhaka division has emerged as the country's dengue hotspot, recording 6,871 cases, including 4,404 infections in Dhaka city alone this year.

According to data from the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Barishal division reported the second-highest number of infections, with 3,647 cases, followed by Chattogram with 3,082 and Khulna with 2,272.

Dhaka division also recorded the highest number of dengue-related deaths, with 26 fatalities, including 25 in Dhaka city. Khulna ranked second with 12 deaths, while Chattogram and Mymensingh reported seven and six deaths, respectively.

A total of 59 people have died from dengue, while 17,880 cases have been reported so far this year. The aforementioned data is from the tally provided by the DGHS as of Thursday.

The data reflects Dhaka's combination of high population density, year-round Aedes mosquito breeding, and inadequate vector control, according to GM Saifur Rahman, associate professor in the Department of Zoology at the National University of Bangladesh.

With its densely packed neighbourhoods, warm climate and abundant breeding sites, Dhaka provides ideal conditions for both Aedes mosquitoes and the dengue virus to circulate throughout the year, making it a dengue hotspot.

"Just a few days ago, while supervising an examination at Central

SEE PAGE 9 COL 1



- 17,880 cases reported nationwide
- 59 deaths so far this year
- Dhaka records 6,871 cases, 26 deaths
- Barishal second in dengue infections
- Cases may rise thru Sept, say experts

No way for Shakib to return now

Says minister; Shakib says he'll come back if security ensured

AGENCIES

The government said yesterday that former Bangladesh cricket captain Shakib Al Hasan has no prospect of returning to play after he joined a media event with ousted prime minister Sheikh Hasina, a convicted fugitive.

Youth and Sports Minister Aminul Haque said the government had previously taken a more open approach towards Shakib, a former lawmaker from Hasina's Awami League, but that his appearance alongside her had changed the situation.

"We had been looking at the matter with considerable flexibility and tolerance. After this, I do not think there is any room to think that way anymore," Aminul said in a statement, reports AFP.

"Someone who has taken the stage with the autocrat no longer has any opportunity to return."

Shakib, 39, joined the event in New Delhi virtually on Wednesday, the second anniversary of the student-

SEE PAGE 9 COL 1

Low Danube in Bulgaria exposes Roman-era bridge

REUTERS, *Sofia*

Exceptionally low water levels on the Danube have exposed parts of the foundations of the ancient Constantine Bridge, giving Bulgarian archaeologists a rare opportunity to document what they describe as one of the Roman Empire's most impressive engineering achievements.



A succession of record-breaking heatwaves in Europe this summer has caused a severe drought in parts of the continent, affecting major waterways such as the Danube and the Rhine.

"For archaeologists, these moments are extremely valuable because nature briefly reveals an object that is hidden beneath the Danube for most of the time," said Pavel Popov of the Regional Historical Museum in Pleven. "It gives us a rare opportunity to observe, document and study it in its real environment."

The bridge, commissioned by Emperor Constantine I and inaugurated in AD 328, linked the ancient city of Ulpia Oescus with Sucidava in what is now Romania.

Football world splits over Infantino

AGENCIES

The fallout from Gianni Infantino's failed FIFA Forward Enterprise (FFE) plan has evolved from a broad revolt into a deeper split within world football, with some of the game's most influential associations now rallying behind the FIFA president while others are demanding his departure.

Yesterday, Argentina's football association (AFA) and the Mexican Football Federation (FMF) have emerged as significant voices in Infantino's defence, while Norwegian Football Federation president Lise Klaveness said that her federation would call for his resignation.

In a letter to Infantino, the AFA backed FIFA's work over the past decade, praising its focus on global development and transparent governance.

The Argentine federation did acknowledge that the FFE proposal had created "far more uncertainties than certainties" and that mistakes had been made. But rather than calling for a change in leadership, the AFA argued that the way forward was to continue working under FIFA's leadership ahead of next year's Congress.

The stance is particularly significant given Argentina's standing in the global game. It also highlights how

SEE PAGE 9 COL 1



People gather outside a school following a shooting in Bang Kruai district, Nonthaburi province, north of Thailand's capital Bangkok, yesterday. PHOTO: AFP

Thai teen kills 7 in rampage at home, school

Takes own life; 30 injured in shooting

AFP, *Nonthaburi*

A 14-year-old boy in Thailand, described as "troubled" and "bullied" by a classmate, killed his grandparents before shooting dead five more people at a school yesterday, police said.

First, he shot dead his two grandparents, using his grandfather's handgun, then went to a secondary school in Nonthaburi province, bordering Bangkok, and killed five school teachers and staff, national police said in a statement.

The 14-year-old perpetrator also died, the statement said, with a police official telling AFP he had killed himself. Officials earlier gave a higher toll of eight dead, which had included the suspect, and initially said students were among the victims.

Dozens of police and emergency responders gathered outside the cordoned-off Debsirin Nonthaburi School, AFP journalists saw, while parents waited to pick up their

SEE PAGE 9 COL 4



Large-tailed Nightjar



Spot-tailed Pit Viper

A campus alive with BIODIVERSITY

Home to hundreds of species, CU offers a rare landscape where people and nature coexist



A shuttle train winds through the sprawling green campus of Chittagong University.

KHENGSAPRUE MARMA

As dawn breaks over the rolling hills of Chittagong University, the campus awakens to more than the footsteps of students.

Birds fill the air with their calls, squirrels dart through the treetops, and deep within the forests, wild boars and other elusive animals begin their daily search for food.

With its mosaic of forests, hills, lakes, and streams, the landscape supports remarkable biodiversity. As students, teachers, and wild animals share this space, the university remains a rare place where nature is inseparable from everyday campus life.

Nestled among the forested hills of Hathazari, CU spans more than 2,100 acres, making it the largest university campus in Bangladesh by area.

Away from the bustle of the city, this vast green expanse has long remained a refuge for diverse species. Around 350 species of wild animals have been recorded here, including about 240 species of birds, 30 species of mammals, 60 species of reptiles, and 24 species of amphibians.

The campus is home to about 25-30 species of snakes, including the King Cobra, Indian Rock Python, and Red-necked Keelback.

All three of Bangladesh's monitor lizard species have been recorded here, although one is extremely rare, while nearly all of the country's forest lizard species are also found in the area.

The presence of Assamese macaques, Northern pig-tailed macaques, wild boars, barking deer, tree squirrels, porcupines, civets, numerous bat species, and tortoises has also been documented.

Among its avian highlights are eagles, Common Green Magpie, Kalij Pheasant, Malayan Night Heron, Slaty-breasted Rail, and the Common Hill Myna, with five of the six subspecies recorded in Bangladesh documented on the campus.

Despite its remarkable biodiversity, the campus has witnessed a noticeable decline in several wildlife species over the years.

Jannatul Ferdous Runa, a student at CU, said her seniors often told her about a time when birds of prey, including eagles, were a common sight and different species of kites regularly soared over the hills.

They also recalled hearing jackals calling through the forests at dusk and occasionally encountering barking deer, pangolins, and even the rare king cobra.



Members of the Society for Snake and Snakebite Awareness conduct a snakebite awareness programme among students at CU.



Members of the Chittagong University Bird Club observe and document various bird species on the university campus.

However, Runa said she has not witnessed these scenes during her time at the university, noting that such wildlife has become increasingly rare.

Meanwhile, the gradual expansion of academic buildings, residential halls, roads, and other infrastructure, along with the leasing of university land for agricultural activities, has placed growing pressure on natural habitats, fragmenting wildlife movement corridors across the campus.

Although such encounters can create fear and misunderstanding, they also present opportunities to promote coexistence rather than conflict.

To encourage that coexistence, several student-led conservation organisations have become actively involved in wildlife awareness and rescue efforts.

On the CU campus, The Society for Snake and Snakebite Awareness (3SA) rescues snakes, promotes safe rescue practices, and educates students and local communities about snakebite prevention and the ecological importance of snakes.

Nafees Hasan Tanim, head of the rescue team at 3SA, said the rich biodiversity of the campus means encounters between people and wildlife remain a part of everyday life.

He said snakes occasionally enter residential halls and academic buildings; wild boars are sometimes spotted near roads and hostels, while injured birds and other wild animals are frequently reported by students and staff.

Meanwhile, the Bird Club of Chittagong University documents the campus's bird diversity, conducts awareness campaigns, and encourages students to appreciate and protect its rich birdlife.

Prof Farid Ahsan of the Zoology department at CU said, "People need to learn to coexist with wildlife. Awareness is the key. Through the efforts of student organisations such as the 3SA and the Bird Club, even a small increase in public awareness has made a difference."



Oriental Garden Lizard

"Today, instead of harming wild animals, many people call rescue teams for help," he added.

Despite these positive initiatives, conservationists say long-term protection will require stronger institutional commitment.

Prof Abdul Wahed Chowdhury of Zoology at the university said the campus should be declared a Biologically Important Area to ensure its rich biodiversity receives greater protection.

Such a designation, he said, would require future infrastructure development and land-use decisions to take the campus's ecological importance into account.

"If the campus is protected and managed sustainably, I believe its biodiversity will increase significantly over the next 10 years," he said.

Protecting the campus alone, however, may not be enough.

Ibrahim Khalil Al Haidar, assistant professor of Zoology, stressed the importance of maintaining ecological connectivity between the CU campus and the adjacent Sitakunda Range under the Forest Department.

He said agricultural expansion has fragmented the natural corridor linking the two areas, disrupting wildlife movement.

Greater collaboration between the university and the Forest Department, he added, could help restore this habitat corridor, allowing animals to move more freely between the two landscapes and reducing wildlife mortality.



Common Green Magpie



Tawny Cat Snake

PHOTOS: RIDWAN MUHIB

GOOD INTENTIONS ARE NOT ENOUGH

Why Bangladesh should rethink orphanages



Women care for children at the Mother Teresa orphanage in Old Dhaka.
PHOTO: MUNIR UZ ZAMAN/AFP

LAILA KHONDKAR

People who establish orphanages or residential institutions for children, and those who generously support them, are undoubtedly motivated by compassion. Their intention is to provide vulnerable children with a safe and better future. Yet an important question deserves greater public attention: Is institutional care really the best way to help children, or could it be causing unintended harm?

While working in Liberia between 2013 and 2014, I had the opportunity, together with my colleagues, to support the government in implementing its deinstitutionalisation policy. The initiative had several components—reuniting children living in institutions (locally known as "missions") with their families, providing parents with start-up capital and basic business training, strengthening positive parenting skills, and connecting families to essential services.

The results were encouraging. Children who had been separated from their families were able to return home, enrol in local schools, and grow up within their communities. Previously, many parents had sent their children to mission schools, believing this was the only way they could access education. What they often did not realise was that the quality of education was poor, and the living conditions in these institutions were no better than those in their own homes.

Poverty, disability, conflict, natural disasters and social exclusion are among the primary drivers of institutionalisation. For many struggling parents, placing a child in an institution appears to be the only way to secure access to education, healthcare or other basic services. Children from ethnic minority communities, children with disabilities, children living with HIV, and children born outside marriage are particularly vulnerable to institutionalisation. Globally, between 80 and 96 per cent of children living in institutions have at least one living parent. In many cases, they could remain safely with their families if those underlying challenges were adequately addressed.

People who establish orphanages or residential institutions for children, and those who generously support them, are undoubtedly motivated by compassion. Their intention is to provide vulnerable children with a safe and better future. Yet an important question deserves greater public attention: Is institutional care really the best way to help children, or could it be causing unintended harm?

For decades, orphanages have been viewed as a charitable response for children who have lost parental care. However, research from around the world tells a different story. Evidence increasingly shows that children thrive not in institutions but in nurturing family environments.

THE HIDDEN COST OF INSTITUTIONAL CARE

Research consistently shows that institutionalisation has profound and lasting consequences for children's physical, cognitive and emotional development. According to Kevin Browne's The Risk of Harm to Young Children in Institutional Care (2009), babies and toddlers who spend more than six months in institutional care without appropriate support may never fully recover from its developmental impacts. The consequences often extend well beyond childhood. Young people leaving institutions are significantly more likely to experience poverty, mental health problems, homelessness, substance misuse, high-risk sexual behaviour and involvement in crime.

Save the Children's report, Keeping Children Out of Harmful Institutions: Why We Should Be Investing in Family-Based Care (2009), concludes that institutions are neither the safest nor the most appropriate place for children to grow up. Children living in institutions face heightened risks of violence, abuse, neglect and trafficking. Disturbingly, harm may also come from those entrusted with their care—including staff members, volunteers, officials and visitors. Such cases have been documented in countries across the world.



Abandoned vehicles were parked in the front yard of Shishu Paribar, a girls' orphanage under the Ministry of Social Welfare in Dhaka's Tejgaon area. The space, which could have served as a playground for the girls, instead became an ideal breeding ground for mosquitoes, as rainwater collected inside the rusting shells. Photo taken in November 2019.
PHOTO: STAR

In many countries, childcare institutions operate with little regulation, making it possible for almost anyone to establish one. As a result, institutional care can become a business model rather than a child protection response. In Nepal, for example, around 90 per cent of orphanages rely entirely on foreign funding. Some institutions actively recruit children because their funding depends on the number of children they accommodate. I witnessed a similar dynamic in Liberia. When the government began implementing its deinstitutionalisation policy, many mission authorities resisted the initiative because they feared it would threaten the livelihoods of their staff.

Every child has the right to grow up in a safe and caring family environment. Even the best-managed institutions, established with the noblest intentions, cannot replace the love, stability and consistent relationships that children need to develop secure emotional attachments. Supporting families before separation occurs should therefore be a priority. This support may include cash transfers, parenting education, day-care services, professional social work support, and better access to healthcare and education.

UNNECESSARY INSTITUTIONALISATION OF CHILDREN IN BANGLADESH

Various NGOs and international agencies estimate that Bangladesh has between four and five million orphaned children. However, this figure includes many children who have either a living mother or a living father. According to reports based on data from the Department of Social Services, Bangladesh has 85 government-run "Shishu Poribar" institutions with accommodation for approximately 10,300 children. In addition, around 4,000 privately operated orphanages and residential child care institutions exist across the country. Yet these figures do not tell the whole story because Bangladesh still lacks a comprehensive national database covering all residential care facilities.

Conditions in many orphanages and residential care facilities in Bangladesh remain far from ideal. Shortages of nutritious food, trained caregivers, educational materials and healthcare services are common. Media reports have repeatedly highlighted cases of neglect, abuse and violence within such institutions.

In Bangladesh, poverty, family breakdown, disability and inadequate social protection compel many families to place their children in institutions so that they can secure education, healthcare or other basic necessities. But poverty alone should never justify separating a child from his or her family. Instead of removing children, we should remove the barriers that prevent families from caring for them.

INSTITUTIONS SHOULD BE THE LAST RESORT

We must recognise that families are not always safe places. Some children experience violence, abuse, neglect or exploitation within their own homes. Some parents also cannot support their children, even if they want to. When parents are unable or unwilling to protect their children and provide food, healthcare, education and a nurturing environment for their development, the state has a responsibility to provide appropriate family-based alternatives. These include kinship care, foster care, small group homes and, where appropriate, adoption. Decisions about placing a child in alternative care should always be based on a comprehensive assessment of the child's individual circumstances and the available options. The child's own views should be heard, and the principle of the best interests of the child must guide every decision. Whatever form of alternative care is chosen, effective regulation, monitoring and accountability are essential.

These principles are reflected in the UN Guidelines for the Alternative Care of Children, adopted by the United Nations General Assembly on 18 December 2009 (Resolution A/RES/64/142). The Guidelines are built around two fundamental objectives, which include preventing unnecessary separation of children from their families and ensuring that any out-of-home care is safe, appropriate and tailored to each child's needs. They complement the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child by providing practical guidance for protecting children who have lost parental care or are at risk of losing it. International standards are clear: institutional care should be the option of last resort. When placement in a residential facility is unavoidable, it should be temporary and provided in a small, family-like environment that meets recognised quality standards.

The Guidelines also provide governments with a roadmap for strengthening national child protection systems. This includes reforming laws and policies, investing in a skilled social service workforce, allocating adequate resources, establishing minimum standards of care, and creating robust monitoring and accountability mechanisms. Countries such as Indonesia, Georgia and Liberia have used the Guidelines to reform their care systems and gradually shift away from unnecessary institutionalisation towards family-based care.

Many countries are now investing heavily in preventing unnecessary family separation by strengthening social protection systems, providing direct assistance to vulnerable families, and expanding family-based alternative care. Where residential care continues to exist, there is a growing shift away from large institutions towards smaller, family-like settings.

RETHINKING OUR PRIORITIES

The Children Act 2013 focuses on creating a comprehensive alternative care system for children in Bangladesh who cannot safely remain with their parents. Before placing a child in institutional care, the authorities are required to consider the family's circumstances and determine the arrangement that best serves the child's best interests. However, these provisions are yet to be implemented, and children continue to be placed in institutions without proper assessment.

Bangladesh's continued dependence on institutional care reflects a significant weakness in the country's child protection system. While global evidence and international child rights organisations advocate family-based care, our practice still leans heavily towards institutional solutions. This gap needs urgent attention.

Institutional care continues to enjoy widespread public support and remains the most heavily funded form of alternative care in Bangladesh. Research from several African countries suggests that institutional care costs between six and ten times more than supporting children within their own families. Investing in family-based care is therefore not only better for children but also represents a far more efficient use of resources.

Having worked on alternative care reforms in several countries, I have repeatedly observed that awareness of the harmful effects of institutionalisation remains limited—not only among parents and community members but also among government service providers and the general public. There is a need for greater awareness in this regard. All concerned must understand that their "misguided kindness" is harming children.

Government, development partners, the private sector, philanthropists and local communities all have a role to play in strengthening family-based care systems. If our goal is to improve children's well-being, our investments should focus on helping families stay together—not on building more institutions. The availability of funding should not automatically translate into constructing additional orphanages. Unfortunately, however, that seems to be the prevailing tendency.

Practical measures, including cash assistance, positive parenting programmes, day-care services, social work support, and improved access to education and healthcare, could prevent unnecessary institutionalisation of children. For children who have already been separated from their families, every effort should be made to reunite them whenever this is safe and in their best interests.

The Bangladesh Government should now ask itself some difficult but necessary questions. Are we investing enough to strengthen vulnerable families before separation occurs? Are we building a diverse, well-regulated system of family-based alternative care within a functional child protection system? Are we investing in the best interests of the child—or simply in the survival of institutions?

Before deciding to donate to an orphanage, we should ask: Could this same support help a child remain safely within a nurturing family environment? If the answer is yes, then perhaps our greatest act of compassion is not to donate to the institution but to support families so that children never have to leave them in the first place.

Laila Khondkar *is an international development worker.*

Why Dhaka's waterlogging crisis has little to do with heavy rain

MD. KHALEQUZZAMAN



Vehicles navigate severe waterlogging in Dhaka. PHOTO: PRABIR DAS

Recent flooding in greater Chattogram and the Hill Tracts districts has caused many deaths and severe economic hardship for millions. At the same time, Dhaka City's residents are recovering from yet another waterlogging incident that paralysed the city. In recent years, waterlogging following average rainfall has become part of daily life for the city's residents. Dhaka City experienced major waterlogging incidents in 2021, 2023, 2024, 2025, and 2026, with daily rainfall during these incidents ranging between 71 and 196 millimetres (mm).

The difference between flooding and waterlogging may sound like an academic distinction to someone whose life has been paralysed by water invading their home and destroying their belongings. But understanding that difference matters: without it, solving the problem becomes far harder. Flooding is a natural phenomenon for all rivers and creeks, and floodplains are an integral part of river ecosystems. Most rivers in the world flood every few years—an essential natural process that rejuvenates floodplains through the deposit of nutrient-rich silt. During a flood, water from a river spreads across its floodplain, which can be thought of as the river's backyard. The majority of the land area that makes up Bangladesh belongs to the floodplains of its major rivers and their tributaries. Humans occupy floodplains for their own benefit, depriving rivers of their natural rights. Human activity changes land use and land cover, replacing natural vegetation, wetlands, and soft soils that absorb and store rainwater with impervious surfaces that cannot absorb or store it, sending most rainwater instead towards nearby low-lying areas and rivers as run-off.

This excess run-off drives the resulting increase in flooding on human-occupied floodplains: an increase of 20 percent in impervious surfaces within a watershed can increase flooding by 100 percent. In certain areas of Dhaka City—including Bangshal, Sutrapur, Kalabagan, Hazaribagh, Mirpur, and Rampura—impervious surface cover has reached over 90 percent, meaning that almost all the rainwater from a rain event becomes surface run-off, causing flooding. Between 1980 and 2024, the city's built-up area increased sevenfold, while 60 percent of its wetlands and water bodies disappeared over the same period. As naturally vegetated, forested, or barren land is urbanised, the lag time between peak rainfall and peak discharge in a receiving stream or river shortens, and peak flow increases—meaning both the frequency and the magnitude of urban flooding rise.

Waterlogging, by contrast, occurs when rainwater cannot reach nearby drains, canals, and rivers because its path is blocked by buildings, roads, embankments, and other infrastructure. In recent years, major cities and population centres on Bangladesh's riverbanks have experienced severe waterlogging and drainage congestion following even average rainfall—including in parts of Dhaka, Chattogram, Sylhet, Sunamganj, Rangamati, Cox's Bazar, and Bandarban. Many flooding incidents in urban areas, in fact, display the characteristics of waterlogging. The remainder of this article analyses the underlying causes of waterlogging in Dhaka City as a case study, and proposes framework solutions.



Map showing the existing lakes and water bodies and their connections to the flow-accumulation network.

The literature identifies several underlying causes of waterlogging in Dhaka City's urban centres: rising land-surface imperviousness driven by changing land use; a decline in the wetlands and water-flow zones that once served as natural storage; encroachment on floodplains, which reduces infiltration; a reduced water-carrying capacity in surface flows as natural creeks disappear or shrink; impediments to run-off created by roads, buildings, and other infrastructure built along flow paths; inadequate and poorly functioning storm drains; unplanned urbanisation without adequate retention reservoirs, open spaces, causeways, bridges, and culverts; excessive rainfall driven by climate change and the urban heat island effect; surface-water and run-off management projects that are not grounded in watershed-based hydrological principles; and a lack of coordination between the authorities responsible—Rajdhani Unnayan Kartripakkha (RAJUK), Dhaka North City Corporation (DNCC), Dhaka South City Corporation (DSCC), the Water Supply and Sewerage Authority (WASA), and the Bangladesh Water Development Board (BWDB).

Annual rainfall in Dhaka City ranged from 1,200 to 3,000 mm between 1991 and 2021. A 2022 study (Islam 2022) found a total of 70 waterlogging incidents over that period, of which 2 were considered severe (2004 and 2009) and 14 major. The total number of waterlogging incidents has been rising: the city recorded 42 incidents in the five years between 2017 and 2021 (8.4 a year), compared with only 28 incidents—1.12 a year—between 1991 and 2017. The severity of waterlogging depends on the total amount of rainfall and its duration and intensity. The 2004 and 2009 incidents, for example, brought a total of 341 mm and 333 mm of rainfall, respectively. But total rainfall is not the only factor: 56 mm of rainfall in 2013 caused major waterlogging because its hourly intensity reached 28 mm. On average, about 70 mm of rainfall over a 10-hour period appears sufficient to cause major waterlogging in Dhaka City.

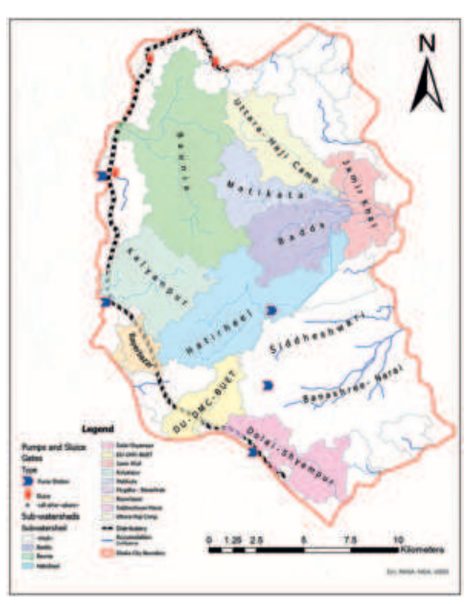
Assessments by the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) indicate that total monsoon-season rainfall over South Asia, including Bangladesh, is projected to increase, with heavier downpours and greater year-to-year variability, even as some areas see shorter or more erratic rainy seasons. At the same time, the risk of extreme rainfall events—very heavy rain over a single day or several days—is expected to rise substantially as global warming progresses.

Spatial and temporal distribution patterns of waterlogging

The spatial distribution of waterlogging shows that incidents are concentrated mainly in the western parts of Dhaka City, predominantly in Mirpur-10, Shere Bangla Nagar, Tejgaon, Mohammadpur, Hazaribagh, Kalabagan, Dhanmondi, Shahjahanpur, Khilgaon, Rampura, Motijheel, New Market, Azimpur, Lalbagh, Chakbazar, and Bangshal. It should be noted that, despite the western embankment running from Gabtoli to Sadarghat, waterlogging remains common in the western part of the city. Of the 300 locations that experienced waterlogging between 1991 and 2021, about 55 were waterlogged during the 2004 incident and 30 during the 2009 incident. A Geographic Information System (GIS)- and Remote Sensing (RS)-based study found that the south and south-western parts of Dhaka were more susceptible to waterlogging hazards; almost 35 percent of the city falls within the high- to very high-vulnerability zone for waterlogging.

Until 1991, waterlogging was confined to the western side of the city. In recent years (2013–2021), waterlogged areas have spread to the north and east. Waterlogging is most intense around BUET-Shahid Minar, Siddeshwari-Magbazar, Mirpur-10 and the Proshika area in Mirpur, Satmasjid, Shyamoli, and Rampura.

This author used a Digital Elevation Model (DEM)—a digital map of the land's elevation—to delineate the surface flow-accumulation areas. These flow-accumulation areas mark the locations where surface run-off is likely to collect after a rainfall event. They are characterised by low topographic elevation and are therefore the locations most likely to collect rainwater and experience waterlogging. They are not necessarily existing khals or rivers, though they would be expected to coincide with them. However, these flow-accumulation areas do not always coincide with the existing and abandoned khals in Dhaka City. This may indicate that the city's current elevations have been altered by human activity, and that existing or abandoned khals no longer mark the lowest points in parts of the city because those khals have been filled in or altered through illegal encroachment. It is also possible that the mapped locations and flow orientations of the khals are not accurate. The flow direction of the khals does not always match the inferred flow-accumulation areas. The Narai Khal, for instance, appears on the map to be the city's largest natural drainage network, but the flow accumulation derived from the current DEM shows that the Jamir Khal actually drains the largest part of the eastern half of the city. Part of the Narai Khal also appears to flow from north to south, but the flow-accumulation data indicate that the western half of the Narai Khal now drains its run-off into the Jamir Khal instead. It should be noted that the DEM used here has a resolution of 30 by 30 metres. A higher-resolution DEM would produce better results, but such datasets are available only for purchase and are not in the public domain.

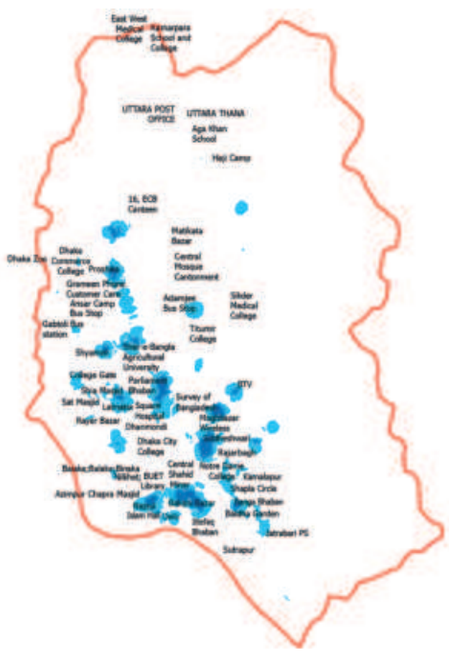


Map showing the sub-watersheds of the flow-accumulation areas, together with the locations of pump stations, sluice gates, and embankments on the western side of the city (adapted from Government of Bangladesh (GoB), 2016).

Framework solutions

This study shows that waterlogging has worsened in Dhaka City over the past few years despite structural measures including western embankments, sluice gates, flood walls, and pump stations. The rationale behind the placement of these sluice gates and pump stations is questionable from a hydrological perspective: these flood-control structures are not located where maximum flow accumulation occurs from a relatively large draining sub-watershed or catchment area.

A similar conclusion can be drawn about the pump stations: the Kallyanpur pumping station is the only one that captures run-off from a relatively large sub-watershed, and the purpose of the pumping station within the Banashree-Narai sub-watershed—or the one to the north of Kallyanpur—is not obvious. Pumping stations are often inadequate to handle the run-off generated by a major rainfall event capable of causing waterlogging. If pumping stations are to be installed for emergency purposes, they should be located at the end of each flow-accumulation channel, with capacity proportional to the run-off generated by the relevant sub-watershed or catchment area. Most of the city's surface run-off, for instance, is generated within the Jamir Khal watershed, which contains several smaller sub-watersheds—including Uttara-Haji Camp, Matikata, Badda, and Begunbari-Hatirjheel. The Narai Khal, Kallyanpur Khal, and Baunia Khal sub-watersheds also generate a substantial share of run-off, and most waterlogging areas fall within the DU-DMC-BUET, Begunbari-Hatirjheel, Siddeshwari, and Badda sub-watersheds. Any sluice gates installed should have flap doors that discharge water out of the city into the receiving rivers, closing automatically when the river's water level rises above that of the khals within the city.



Map showing areas with the most severe (dark blue) and moderate (light blue) waterlogging.

Waterlogging's underlying causes also include impediments created by roads and other infrastructure that interfere with surface run-off, whether as sheet flow or concentrated channel flow, following a rainfall event. One study observed a 22.1 percent increase in built-up area between 1978 and 2018, and found that the area generating very high surface run-off grew from 74.24 to 174.23 square kilometres (km²) over the same period across Dhaka City. The city's combined storm drains are either inadequate or congested by the illegal dumping of garbage and waste. Natural drainage khals have been encroached upon or filled in for development, and land elevation patterns have changed through earth-filling and construction. Agricultural land use, for example, occupied over 80 percent of greater Dhaka City in the 1990s; by 2010, this had fallen to less than 10 percent, with built-up area increasing substantially over the same period. A 2025 report by JagoNews24 found that only 10 percent of the city's storm drains are operational.

The flow-accumulation areas derived from the DEM offer a more accurate representation of the city's current land elevations and surface flow-accumulation patterns. Several studies have recommended establishing a proper drainage system and maintaining and regularly re-excavating existing canals to enhance the retention and carrying capacity of surface run-off. None of these studies, however, has explicitly recommended linking existing canals to the flow-accumulation areas within the context of Dhaka City's watershed boundaries.

Based on the findings and analysis in this study, the following measures are recommended to reduce waterlogging in Dhaka City.

First, the abandoned khals should be identified and dredged according to the flow generated within their respective watershed or catchment areas. Because changing land use patterns in the city have generated additional run-off—driven by both basin development and climate change—simply recovering the abandoned khals will no longer be enough; they will also need to be widened and deepened to accommodate this additional run-off. Under the Government of Bangladesh's 2016 plan, a total of 50.75 kilometres of 13 khals are to be excavated on the eastern side of the city, including the Shahjadpur, Sutivola, Begunbari, Manda, and Zerani khals, along with a further 34.42 kilometres of khals, including the Katasur, Abdullahpur, Baunia, Baishteki, and Shahjahanpur khals. But since the locations of these khals do not coincide with the current flow-accumulation areas, each khal should be adjusted so that nearby flow-accumulation areas are identified and connected to it.

Second, the sub-catchment or sub-watershed map of the flow-accumulation areas should form the basis for managing surface run-off and accumulated flow across the city. The sub-watersheds should guide the identification of areas with maximum run-off accumulation, and a plan should be devised to discharge that accumulated run-off through storm-sewer drains built along the natural slope of the land and aligned with the sub-watershed boundaries. At present, only 38 percent of the city is covered by storm drains (GoB, 2016); this will need to rise to 100 percent. Run-off within each sub-watershed should initially be treated as an independent unit of management; first- and second-order sub-watersheds should subsequently be integrated with higher-order sub-watersheds (third order and above) located downstream. The location and orientation of storm drains should follow the hydrological character of surface run-off—a principle not currently applied in any of the city's flood- or waterlogging-mitigation projects. Surface run-off and flow accumulation in different parts of the city should be managed locally, by sub-catchment area, with drainage pipelines and ditches following the natural slope of the land within each sub-catchment before connecting to the larger catchment downstream.

Third, the road network in waterlogged areas needs culverts and bridges proportional to the catchment areas above each intersection with a flow-accumulation area. The box culvert at Panthapath, for example, should be removed and replaced with a wider bridge.

Fourth, second- and third-order streams should be connected to their receiving natural rivers. The third-order streams in the eastern part of the city—the Jamir Khal and Narai Khal—should, for example, be connected directly to the Balu River, and river floodplains should be connected to the flow-accumulation areas and rivers so that floodwater can spread across the floodplain and reduce flooding downstream. Housing and other infrastructure should be built to accommodate flooding. Pumping floodwater cannot be a permanent or viable solution to waterlogging; where pumping stations are needed, their locations should be determined by the flow-accumulation map—for example, by installing them at the downstream ends of the third-order streams.

Fifth, water-retention reservoirs—such as the Kallyanpur retention reservoir—should be built based on hydrological analysis that maximises flow accumulation into them. The Kallyanpur reservoir's size declined from 92 to 42 hectares between 2010 and 2024, and should be restored to its original size.

Sixth, the city's existing lakes and other water bodies—including Hatirjheel, Banani-Gulshan Lake, and Dhanmondi Lake—need to be connected to the flow-accumulation areas and rivers.

Seventh, existing wetlands and natural flow zones (GoB, 2016) should be preserved and protected from further development.

Eighth, future land-use zoning should encourage a least-impact development approach that guarantees the retention, detention, and infiltration of surface run-off within newly urbanised areas.

Ninth, the size of storm drains needs to be adjusted to accommodate the excess run-off caused by urbanisation and climate-change-driven rainfall. Dhaka's natural drainage network—the Balu, Buriganga, and Turag rivers—will need to be kept clear to allow unimpeded surface-water flow, as Kolkata's own early desilting programme to combat waterlogging illustrates, and their carrying capacity should be adjusted in line with basin-development factors and upstream catchment areas.

Tenth, illegal garbage dumping that obstructs the drainage network needs to be controlled through the enforcement of existing laws and penalties.

Eleventh, best management practices should be adopted in flood-prone and waterlogged areas—retention ponds, reservoirs, rain gardens, rooftop gardens, bioswales in road dividers, a no-harm-downstream policy, and least-impact development, among others.

Twelfth, the authorities responsible for maintaining roadside drains, storm-sewer drains, canals, and rivers in and around Dhaka City—RAJUK, DNCC, DSCC, WASA, and BWDB—need to be brought under a single integrated agency so that the city's natural and storm-sewer drainage network can be better managed and maintained. Alongside this, campaigns to raise citizen awareness of the importance of a clean, green city should be carried out at every level.

Government action alone cannot keep the city liveable and free of waterlogging. A concerted effort by citizens, civil society organisations, academia, and law enforcement agencies will be needed to achieve this goal.

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The fall of an industrial city

Once home to thousands of jute mill workers, Khulna's industrial belt now lies largely abandoned, with its people leaving too



An aerial view of Khulna city, where a dense, still-growing urban sprawl sits atop a shrinking industrial base.

The industrial belts of Khalishpur, Daulatpur, and Rupsha were once alive with production: jute mills, textile factories, paper mills, hardboard factories, match plants. Tea stalls, grocery stores, transport operators, and rental housing all depended on the steady flow of workers and wages

PHOTOS: HABIBUR RAHMAN

DIPANKAR ROY, *Khulna*

Enamul Kabir, 54, arrived in Khulna from Nalchity in Jhalakathi in August 1992, searching for stable employment. Like thousands of others from the country's southern districts, he was drawn to the city by the promise of jobs in its bustling industrial sector.

He soon found work at Crescent Jute Mills, one of the largest state-owned jute mills in the region, and for almost three decades the mill sat at the centre of his life. The wages let him raise two children and build a modest life in a city that became his new home. In 2020, that life crumbled when the government shut down all 25 state-owned jute mills in the country.

"My children grew up in Khulna. They still want to live here because this city is their home," he said. "But after losing the job, it became impossible to bear the living cost."

Four years ago, facing mounting pressure, he left for his ancestral village, leaving behind decades of memories and a community built around the mill.

For Nasima Akter, 49, the mill closures meant the collapse of a lifetime of hope. She worked there as a casual worker for 16 years, always believing she would become a permanent employee. That never happened. A divorced mother of two, she could no longer afford her rent and moved to a slum-like settlement with her son.

"When the mill closed, I received Tk 114,000 as settlement. It disappeared within months," she said. "Now I work whenever I can. Earlier, shopkeepers trusted us and gave us groceries on credit because they knew we had steady jobs. Now they don't. Even landlords refuse to rent houses to former jute mill workers."

Their stories reflect the struggles of thousands whose lives were built around Khulna's once-thriving industries.

The industrial belts of Khalishpur, Daulatpur, and Rupsha were once alive with production: jute mills, textile factories, paper mills, hardboard factories, match plants. Tea stalls, grocery stores, transport operators, and rental housing all depended on the steady flow of workers and wages. People arrived from Barishal, Jhalakathi, Pirojpur, Bagerhat, Satkhira, and Gopalganj in search of jobs, many settling permanently.

By the 1980s, the three industrial belts together employed tens of thousands of workers. Over the next four decades, most of that disappeared.

AN INDUSTRIAL POWERHOUSE

Khulna's emergence as a major industrial centre began in the 1950s and 60s. Its location offered clear advantages with river routes, including the Rupsha and Bhairab. When the country's second-largest seaport, Mongla Port, was established in 1954, it broadened the scope for Khulna significantly.

Raw materials moved in efficiently and finished goods moved out; abundant labour and nearby natural resources completed the conditions for industrial expansion. Factories sprang up across Khalishpur, Daulatpur, and Rupsha. None mattered more than jute.

Crescent Jute Mills, Platinum Jubilee Jute Mills, Star Jute Mills, and other state-owned factories became symbols of the city's industrial success. At their peak, the region's seven state-owned jute mills employed nearly 50,000 permanent and temporary workers. Entire neighbourhoods, schools, markets, and housing colonies grew up around them.

FIRST MAJOR BLOW: NEWSPRINT MILLS

For many, the decades-long slow decline began with Khulna Newsprint Mills, which started production using raw materials from the Sundarbans in 1959.

For years, the mill, with an annual capacity of 48,000 tonnes, supplied newsprint to newspapers nationwide. That changed in the 1990s, as the government liberalised trade at the behest of multilateral lenders, including the World Bank.

The withdrawal of a 75 percent import duty on newsprint in fiscal year 1995-96 made imported paper more competitive and cut demand for the mill's output. Rising furnace oil prices, working-capital shortages, raw material constraints, and government-controlled pricing pushed it deeper into losses, which reached Tk 284 crore between 1995 and 2002.





The remains of Khulna Newsprint Mills in Khalishpur. The factory shut down in 2002 after 43 years of operation, leaving around 3,200 workers jobless.

The mill closed on November 30, 2002, ending 43 years of operation and costing around 3,200 workers their jobs.

DADA MATCH FACTORY

Established in 1955 in Rupsha, the match factory once relied on Gewa timber from the Sundarbans and produced around 12,500 matchboxes a day, supporting countless families for decades.

It closed on August 18, 2010, after leaseholder Bhaiya Group cited heavy financial losses, putting around 1,950 workers out of work. Many left Khulna for work elsewhere. Others stayed and struggled to adapt.

A FORGOTTEN LANDMARK

Established in 1931 as Acharya Prafulla Chandra Cotton Mill on 25.6 acres in the heart of the city, Khulna Textile Mills was shut down by the government in 1993, laying off around 1,600 workers and employees.

THE END OF JUTE MILLS AND AN ERA

The biggest blow came on July 1, 2020, when the government shut down 25 state-run jute mills operated by the Bangladesh Jute Mills Corporation (BJMC) amid mounting losses.

The mills employed more than 50,000 workers nationally across permanent, temporary, and substitute categories; seven were in Khulna, employing more than 29,000 workers, including around 15,000 permanent employees. Counting the jute mill closures, more than 34,000 people have lost their jobs in Khulna since 2002.

The impact rippled through the local economy. Tota Mia, a mobile financial service (MFS) agent at Chitrali Market, said daily transactions at his outlet had fallen from Tk 35,000 to Tk 40,000 to about one-tenth of that amount after the mills closed six years ago.

"Before their shifts and after, [workers] would crowd the shops to send money through bKash, recharge mobile phones, and pay electricity bills," he said. After the mills closed, business fell, leading to the decline of MFS agents in the market from more than a dozen to four.

"From the front of Chitrali Market to Peoples Goal Chattar there were more than 150 small and large garment shops. Every Thursday, after workers received their wages, the market would see a shopping spree," said Swapan Howlader, who once owned a clothing store there.

Unable to sustain the losses, he closed the shop, and now alters old trousers and clothes on the pavement beside the market. "Now I am struggling just to pay the shop rent, electricity bills, and household expenses. Many days pass without a single customer."

'NOT EVEN 1,000 NEW JOBS IN 10 YEARS'

No major industry has emerged over the last decade to fill the void left by the closure of the state-owned jute mills. Private investment has stalled, generating limited employment. The most notable one is the shrimp industry.

"We once hoped that the shrimp industry would become one of the main driving forces of Khulna's economy. But that industry is also facing a severe crisis now," said Abdul Jabbar, a former director of the Khulna Chamber of Commerce and Industry (KCCI).

Nearly 80 percent of shrimp processing factories have become virtually defunct due to raw material shortages, declining production, international competition, and structural problems, he said. "Thousands of workers have lost their jobs and are living a subhuman existence."

Around 120 shrimp and fish processing plants registered with the Bangladesh Frozen Foods Exporters Association once operated in the region. Even a few years ago, 35 to 40 were running. Today, only 8 to 10 remain operational and continue exporting.

"This is a clear indication of the decline in Khulna's industrial and export sectors," Jabbar said, citing a lack of investment, weak infrastructure, the energy crisis, and policy uncertainty.

To revitalise Khulna's economy, there is no alternative to establishing new industries, reviving existing ones, and providing special incentives to export-oriented sectors, he said.

Kazi Hafizur Rahman, another former KCCI director, said the 2022 inauguration of the Padma Bridge had raised hopes of new industrial investment.

"While the bridge has undoubtedly improved connectivity and reduced transportation time, the level of industrial investment the business community had anticipated has not yet materialised," he said.

Some jobs have appeared in logistics, real estate, healthcare, education, retail, IT, and small-scale agro-processing, but "large-scale manufacturing industries capable of generating significant employment have yet to emerge in the region," he said.

He pointed to the lack of gas supply, high energy costs, bureaucratic complexity, and the absence of targeted policy incentives for the southwest.

"Khulna has all the ingredients to become a major economic hub -- a seaport, rail and road connectivity, proximity to international markets, and a skilled workforce. What is needed now is a comprehensive government strategy to develop Khulna as a dedicated economic and industrial zone," Hafizur said. "In the last 10 years, not even 1,000 jobs have been created here in total."

Kazi Aminul Haque, a former KCCI president, said no new jute mill, public or private, has been established in the region in recent years. Despite the region's potential centred on Mongla Port, port-based industrialisation and investment have yet to reach expected levels.

PROMISES AND REALITY

When the state-owned jute mills closed, the government promised to revive them by leasing the factories to private investors. Six years later, little has changed. Four mills have been leased out for 30 years to lessees including footwear and pharmaceutical manufacturers, feed producers, and foreign investors.

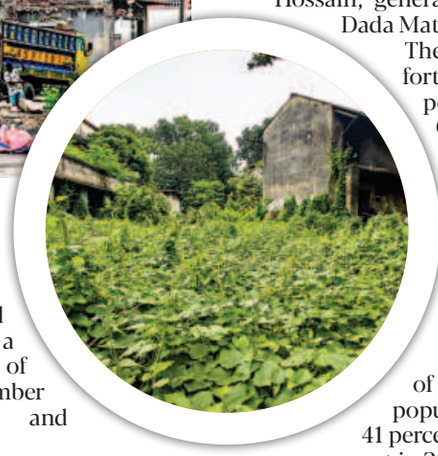
Production is currently underway at Eastern Jute Mills and Khalishpur Jute Mills; Daulatpur Jute Mills also resumed production after being leased by BJMC, though it is now temporarily suspended. The lease agreements do not require operators to manufacture jute goods or any specific product. They are free to produce whatever they choose.

The Newsprint Mills was listed for privatisation in 2005. Two tender attempts failed, and the mill was returned to the industries ministry in 2008. Plans for a textile village and other redevelopment proposals have since stalled, and trees now cover much of the abandoned site.

The Bangladesh Chemical Industries Corporation, which owns the mill, has sold 50 acres of the land to North-West Power Generation Company for a power plant.

The Dada Match Factory's infrastructure also remains unused, its machinery deteriorating while former workers wait for the factory to reopen.

"We urged the government to take steps to resume its operation without any further delay," said HM Shahadat Hossain, general secretary of the Dada Match Workers' Union.



The city's fading fortunes show in its population. Khulna City's population peaked at 770,000 in 2001 and fell to 718,000 in 2022, according to Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics census data.

The urban share of Khulna Division's population dropped to 41 percent in 2022 from 55 percent in 2001.

"It is heartbreaking to see the decline of what was once a vibrant industrial hub. Thousands of workers have lost their livelihoods, while vast industrial estates remain abandoned," said Sheikh Ashrafuzzaman, president of the Greater Khulna Development Movement Coordinating Committee.

"This is both an economic and social tragedy."